

Free Indeed!

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 17. 7/13/2021 (7/26 civil date) SYNAXIS OF THE ARCHANGEL GABRIEL

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Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter at least twice each month. This is the 17th sent to 81 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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Questions about APOSTLES PETER AND PAUL

QUESTION 1 When is the feast of Apostles Peter and Paul? What precedes this feast, and when does the preparation for this commemoration begin?

QUESTION 2 How is the Apostles fast different than any other fasting period of the year? There is a problem with the length of the Apostles fast for those who follow the New Calendar. Why is this, and do you think this is important or not important?

QUESTION 3 What is the prokeimenon for all of the Apostles. Why?

QUESTION 4 Paul was known as the Apostle to the Gentiles, but St Peter was heavily involved in the mission to the Gentiles also, and was in fact, active in this mission well before Paul. What significant event occurred that convinced Peter to evangelize the Gentiles?

QUESTION 5 How and where did Peter die? Who predicted this?

QUESTION 6 How and where did Paul die?

QUESTION 7 Discuss the conversion of St Paul. What was his former life? How was he converted?

QUESTION 8 The Holy Apostles Peter's experiences with Christ, as recounted in the Gospels, are particularly vivid and instructive for us. Compare and contrast Peter's first reported encounter with Christ, and the last. Hint: they were both in the same area, while Peter was busy performing the same work, although Peter's reaction was very different.

QUESTION 9 There is something anachronistic about the icon of Pentecost. It shows 12 apostles in a circle, each with tongues of fire over his head. The problem is that there were only 11 apostles at the time; Matthias had not yet been chosen by lot (this event happened after Pentecost). Who is the 12th man in the icon, and why?

QUESTION 10 What feast closely follows St. Peter and Paul? Why?

Prison Ministry News

We are preparing to accept our first resident in the Marshall house. It should be happening sometime in August. A young man is moving to Marshall. He has already put in to the post office his change of address, and the inmate has been given his information so the parole board can contact him.

I sure hope we will be able to make it possible for other people to parole, but we have to start small, or else we don't start at all. We're making a real leap of faith here. Generally, when a person "leaps," they should know what's in front of them when they're leaping, but we have no idea. So maybe it's a leap of faith, or perhaps it's just a leap of stupidity, but with God helping us, it will be successful, whatever that will mean.

I want the house to function as a lay community. There will be evening prayer every night. I'm going to get a Compline book together and maybe some other things. It'll be relatively simple, and they will be able to do it whether they can sing or not. Hopefully, some people will learn to sing. I hope that there will be some form of morning prayer also, but of course, that is dependent on people's jobs.

Jude will probably be present for all of the evening prayers. He is the one who moved from our parish to his home in Marshall and bought a property that his father had been using to help the homeless. Now we're going to see if we can help those who come from prison to have homes. I need everyone living there to commit that they will be doing communal prayer every day. This will not be a monastery, but it will be a community, and a fundamental principle of monasteries is that there is public prayer morning and evening. We must at least do it in the evening.

We talk about other things, such as whether or not alcohol will be allowed. What should we do about smokers? That seems to be the most addictive substance known to man, and pretty much every former drug addict I know smokes. I hate the stuff, so it absolutely will be forbidden on the property (including sidewalks just outside of the property!) The former administrator of the house didn't allow people to smoke at all, at the property, or anywhere. We figure that if people want to have a beer (assuming, of course, that their parole agreement allows it), they can go over to Jude's property and sit on the back porch and maybe, if they're lucky, see a deer. That way, the facility will be alcohol-free except, of course, of wine for the Eucharist.

Jude and I were just talking recently, and we laughed a little bit because we have no idea what we're getting into. I suppose we can at least say all regarding things are happening is that it's not boring.

I hope to be able to go to Marshall every other week. I will leave on Friday morning after liturgy and come back Saturday afternoon after liturgy. I can't afford to be gone on the weekends because stuff is too busy here at the parish. Things are more active than they've ever been in my pastoral life. They are stretching my organizational capabilities way past their breaking point. The other idea is that twice a month, the guys will come up Saturday morning and stay the night come to vigil and go to liturgy and then go home. Eventually, it would be great to have a priest in residence, but in the meantime, if I go twice a month and the people in the house go twice a month to McKinney, then I will see everybody eight times a month. The great advantage of people coming to McKinney is they get to see parish community life.

A Word from Fr Seraphim

I have learned the hard way that the most critical thing is when a person gets out of prison; that is, if I am going to be able to help them in any way, is that they must talk to me! They must be honest! Honesty is, unfortunately, very rare. You must make sure that you are one of the rare ones! People lie because they say what they think I want to hear. Every single person I've known that's got out of prison that has had troubles, whether they were legal troubles, drug troubles, relationship troubles,

NB:Gleanings for the Holy Fathers

"NB" is an abbreviation for fancy Latin phrase: "note well". It is certainly important to "note well" holy things. This abbreviation is used in a lot of social media.

Said the old man: There is no victory when you hate and crush your enemies. It is not victory if the joy that makes others sad. You don't win victory even when you could command the whole world. Only one true victory exists: when others crucify you, and you forgive them and love them.

"It is joyful to feel that we do not and cannot have any enemies among men, but only unhappy brethren, who are deserving of pity and help, even when, through misunderstanding, they become our enemies and fight against us. Woe! They do not understand that the enemy is found within ourselves, and that first of all one must cast him out of oneself, and then also help others to do the same. We have only one enemy: the devil and his evil spirits. But man, no matter how far he has fallen, never loses certain sparks of light and goodness which may be blown into a bright flame. So, for us there is no reason to fight against people, even when they consistently send against all kind of blows and rebukes ... To fight against people is to take a false position regarding our enemies. Even if we succeed, we gain nothing from such a fight, but rather become estranged from our own success." -Martyr Roman Medved, Letter to His Daughter from the Gulag, 1932

"The great misfortune of our times is that people consider it to be a virtue to have a liberal attitude toward matters of faith and morality. Many consider it their duty to implant such a liberal attitude toward faith and morality in the souls of the Russian people...

To justify themselves, they present arguments that seem to merit our attention. They say: every man can judge religious matters from his own point of view and freely express his convictions, whatever they may be, according to his conscience, and he must respect the religious convictions of others. No one will object to freedom of religion and of the conscience. One must not, however, forget that Christian faith is not a human invention, but rather the word of God, and it cannot be changed to suit people's concepts. If people's convictions stand in opposition to the Divine truth, is it reasonable to recognize these convictions, to consider them correct and to guide one's life by them? We must, of course, be tolerant of those who do not agree with us, and bear with even those who have clearly gone astray, but we must turn away from their errors, and prove that they are unfounded. The pastors of the Christian Church and all sincere followers of Christ's teachings should consider this their duty..."New-martyr Metropolitan Vladimir, "archpastoral address", August, 1917, on the eve of the convocation of an extraordinary congress of the Kievan diocese

<http://www.orthodox.net/russian/m/vladimir-metropolitan-and-hieromartyr-of-kyiv.html>

"There will come a time when only those who feel the grace of the Spirit will be able to distinguish good from evil, for on its own, the human mind cannot discern. There will be times of great confusion and only the Holy Spirit can save us.

leaving the church troubles, depression, anxiety, or whatever, didn't talk to me or they acted as if things were okay when eventually, it was really clear that they were not okay. It is critical that a person talks to me. Many people seem not to want to talk to me because they don't want to disappoint me. That's very disappointing! It is especially disappointing because I'm well aware that I'm not anybody. I don't know why anybody would want to try to impress me. (Priest Seraphim Holland)

So, pray my beloved, pray so you may not enter into [temptation] deception! For only through prayer we can receive God's grace. If we do not pray and continue in laziness and carelessness, then it is possible to lose the instinct of repentance. God forbid that we may not lose conscious!" Holy Elder Justin (Pärvu)

Bishop Constantine said, "The meaning of life is the salvation of our souls. That makes every decision, no matter how difficult easier. One has to ask, first, 'Is this for my salvation?' If the answer is yes, we should do the thing, no matter how difficult. And if the answer is no, we should not do it, no matter how pleasant. And thus life, for a Christian, is easier and less complicated." (Bishop Constantine was a priest in our church, ROCOR, and I know him personally. He was a very holy man. He had an incredible stack of cards for his commemorations. Priest Seraphim)

Do not be afraid of temptations and if you fall many times, get up. Do not lose your composure. Do not be discouraged. Temptations are like clouds and will pass. Let the devil fight, let him throw us down.

Again and again let us get up, let us run to the Virgin Mary and Christ and especially in the Tradition of Christ the Church: in our spirituality, in our confession, in Holy Communion. We all need words of consolation. No one is saved alone, but through his brother. Here is what we all need: a word of consolation and faith. This is what we need. Help each other a little bit and so we move on. Do not despair! God has it! +St Joseph the Hesychast

"This is a hard teaching. Who can accept it?" "If a man insults me, kills my father, my mother, my brother, and then gouges out my eye, as a Christian it is my duty to forgive him. We who are pious Christians ought to love our enemies and forgive them. We ought to offer them food and drink, and entreat God for their souls. And then we should say: 'My God, I beseech Thee to forgive me, as I have forgiven my enemies.'" +St Kosmas Aitolos

"There is no greater blessing than to be a priest in the 21st century. We get to be the ones who are bearers of the message of hope in a hopeless world. We have the words of life, we have Christ Himself, Christ has given us the truth about God and the truth about Man and this is what the world is waiting for. To know that they can have, that they are made for communion with God.

The last year I was in Greece and had a conversation with an abbess and this poor woman speaks to thousands of people a year. Every once in a while I get to talk with her and she looks exhausted because he sees and talks with so many people and its tiring for her, and the last time I was with her was in last winter and I asked her, because I was curious of what the patterns were, "what are you seeing, what are you hearing, what are people bringing to you and what is going on."

And she said, "oh that's easy – **they are looking for a true human being, a true man, they are looking for a true priest**, they are looking for a

true monk, and they are not finding that person anywhere.” To hear this coming from this woman that carried the weight of the world, or at least that city, I felt at that moment that I had to do more.

We could all be doing more...In a wealthy society, it's not significant to offer more wealth, but in a poor society, a place reduced to abject poverty it is a blessing to offer something small, and how much more is it a blessing to offer the life of Christ that is within you. In a country or society where sin abounds, it is the greatest blessing in the world to give the gift of God's grace, Paul in Romans says: “where sin abounded, grace abounded all the more.” Even if things are so bad, what about the teaching of Paul in Romans here, and even though this may be the most degenerated phase of Western civilization, could be the end, who knows?

It's probably also the worst period in the life of the Church, or it's certainly no golden age. In any case, even today, but especially today, where sin abounds grace continues to abound and more abundantly, as St Paul said, but as I mentioned we can't communicate that grace if we ourselves don't have it or have not experienced it or have not been transformed by it. In other words, we cannot feed hungry or thirsty souls if we are ourselves starved of God and His grace.”

- Archimandrite Maximos Constas, 'Counsels On the Holy Priesthood,' Lecture One: The Ideal of the Holy Priesthood.

My brotherly advice: however desperate the situation, do not despair. You cannot stop the pain of your soul, but it is out of this pain that the

power of prayer emerges. Sighs from the depth of your soul will reach the height of eternity.” Archimandrite Sophrony (Sakharov).

‘My advice to you is not to believe in any premonition that evokes despair and dismal state of mind, but to trust that God will arrange everything. What He arranges is always needful and saving for us.’ St Ambrose of Optina.

We must abandon ourselves to the hands of God with absolute trust and view every tribulation as a gift sent to us by the love of God. The person who has great trust in God delights in everything. Whether he is sick, or is hungry, or is wronged... he believes that God has allowed it all; he hopes in God and remains, always secured, in the harbour of hope in God. St Paisios the Athonite

"First teach your children, not how to correctly take a blessing from a priest, but to give up their seat to the elderly, to reach out a hand to the woman getting off the bus, and to do everything for the sake of Christ. A religious upbringing begins not when a mother teaches to say "Our Father," but when a father teaches his son to thank his mother for his washed shirt and prepared lunch." Fr. Alexander Obcharenko (maybe not a Holy Father, but he is spot on)

Wisdom regarding our days of apostasy, heresy, secularism and irreligious leaders who embrace these things.

The following are quotations from the scriptures and the Fathers, which will be used in a talk that a priest is soon going to be giving. We live in an age where black is called white and white is called black, and love is called hate and hate is called love, and perversity is called a virtue and chastity is called a vice. Some of the entanglements are very subtle, some are crude and obvious, but all of them are used like baseball bats to beat us into submission, 24 hours a day. If we do not have an inner life, this continual warfare will wear down cowards, the weak, the lazy, the ignorant, the self-indulgent, the unwary, and of course anyone who does not pray with intensity and struggle to follow the commandments. The onslaught will wash all of these people away.

Even some of our Orthodox clergy falling into this trap because it is everywhere. We must stand against it not by only railing against it but by living an interior life that is wholly dedicated to the sole purpose in life. You know that purpose! It is the perfection of the soul because we are made in the image of God, and we are destined to obtain God's likeness if we struggle in the commandments, in the church.

Read these quotations carefully. Since some of them are about the priesthood, of your charity, pray for Fr David, Fr Cassian, and me, who are at risk because we are sinful men trying to help other people not be sinful.

i) "Fearful people do not inherit the Kingdom of God," says St. Paul the Apostle

(ii) "When one does not resist in a timely fashion [prompt and suitable time], he gradually becomes incapable of ever resisting again." Unknown

(iii) "We must not mind insulting men, if by respecting them we offend God." Saint John Chrysostom (+407)

(iv) "They will legally introduce carnivals in the Church with a law." - Father Basil Kapsokalyvites (2009)

(v) "Whoever doesn't conform to [follow] CARNIVALISM will be persecuted! You will witness many gross & absurd things!" Father Basil Kapsokalyvites (2009)

(vi) "The floor of Hell is paved with the skulls of bishops" - Saint Athanasius the Great (+373)

(vii) The road to hell is paved with the bones of priests and monks, and the skulls of bishops are the lamp posts that light the path." - Saint John Chrysostom (+407)

(viii) "The time will come for true confession of the Faith! All those who will confess, will be alone and persecuted!"- Saint John Maximovich (+1966)

(ix) "They will find a disease for which they will make a vaccine, which will be mandatory, and which will be the beginning of the sealing" – St Paisios of Mt. Athos (+1994) (Spiritual Awakening)

Prophecies Concerning the Clergy

(i) "A time will come when there will not be the harmony that exists now between the laity and the clergy." St Kosmas of Aetolia (+1779)

(ii) "The clergy will become the worst and most impious of all." St Kosmas of Aetolia (+1779)

(iii) "The Churches of God are going to be deprived of godly and pious shepherds." Saint Nilus (+1651)

(iv) "Christian shepherds, that is, bishops and priests, are going to be filled with vainglory (with some exceptions), utterly failing to distinguish the right way from the left." Saint Nilus (+1651)

(v) "You will travel miles to find a spiritually sound priest. You will travel long distances to find a good spiritual father." Father Basil Kapsokalyvites (2009)

The Great Responsibility of a Priest

(i) Priests May Very Easily Lose Their Salvation

When the Priest dies, the whole parish prays for his repose. When the Bishop dies, the whole diocese prays publicly for his repose. When the Patriarch dies, the whole nation prays for his repose. Some people ask, why the clergy get so much prayers, if they were already dedicated to God their whole lives? Shouldn't we pray more for ordinary people, laymen, because they were not dedicated that much? The responsibility of the priest, and even more that one of the bishop, is terrifying. St. John Chrysostom said that he thinks that many, if not majority of the clergy are in hell, because they failed to keep up with their responsibility. They failed to protect the Holy Eucharist from the sacrilegious receiving by the unprepared Faithful.

They failed to confess Christ at every corner and every moment of their life. This is why the whole Church prays when the clergyman dies. Candidates for priesthood should be aware that they may very easily lose their salvation due to the temptations of the world. Because the priests have greater honour than the angels. -Elder Athanasius of Grigoriou (†1953)

(iii) Elder Athanasius regarded the priesthood with such piety and fear that when he later became Abbot and tonsured some twenty-seven monastics, he never dared to allow anyone to advance to the holy altar. He constantly kept in mind the saying: "Better with a prayer-rope in Paradise

than an epitachelion in hell." - From the book Contemporary Ascetics of Mt. Athos – Volume 1 by Archimandrite Cherubim

(iii) "The silence of the Clergy is Atheism," said St. Gregory of Palamas (†1359)

Priests are Even Higher than Angels and Kings

My brethren, you laymen should be careful not to accuse your priests, not to swear at them, and not to neglect them because you put fire [in your breast] and you will be burned, because priests are even higher than angels and kings. This is how my mind tells me, my brethren, to act. If I were to meet a priest and a king, I would put the priest to sit higher than the king. If I were to meet a priest and an angel, I would first greet the priest and then the angel. Because, my brethren, [the priest] is higher even than the holy altar, higher even than the holy chalice, because the holy chalice is without a soul, but the priest receives the holy Sacraments daily, the holy Body and Blood of our Lord and God Jesus Christ. I, my brethren, have no charges to make against the priest, because they are priests, and they have Christ who punishes them, and whatever mistake they make, our Christ has an iron rod to apply to them (personal sins). St Kosmas of Aetolia

Questions and Answers

Withholding of the Eucharist

Layperson Question: Although I am an Orthodox Christian, there's something I've never quite understood: namely, the withholding of the Eucharist for a period of time from those who've sinned in a serious way, but have given Confession and repented.

I imagine the answer to be something along the lines of the sacred and holy nature of the Eucharist and that it, or more to the point the person, must be protected from partaking unworthily. But again, I'm taking about a person who has partaken of the sacrament of Confession and repented. As I understand it, particularly in the early years of the church, people were sometimes held back from partaking for a period of years depending on the sin.

But since the Eucharist is the cure for our sickness and sinfulness, the very Grace of God for us and our theosis, why should it not be given even more urgently and immediately (following Confession?)

My Answer: It is important - psychologically, at least - for one who has committed a serious (and potentially community damaging) sin that he or she as a penitent demonstrate an actual commitment to changed behavior before his or her restoration to communion. Otherwise, the penitent may lack sufficient religious motivation to change, and come to see such change as actually impossible, treating the sin as somehow normative for them within their life as a Christian - ie. "this is wrong, but I have been accepted anyway, and all I need to do is keep on confessing it and everything is OK." This is a genuine problem - one that confessors run across fairly frequently these days, when epitimia are rarely if ever imposed.

Mind you, the sin in question should be rather serious for this to be a method of cure - but it does make sense given Orthodox theology. One who has baptismal grace and the gift of the Holy Spirit and the grace offered in the Mystery of Reconciliation does not "need" to receive the Holy Mysteries in order to rein in his or her desires and live as a Christian. The gift of the Holy Mysteries - the very Body and Blood of Christ! - is not purely instrumental - it is not a mere tool. It is a celebration, a joyful reunion, a uniting of ourselves and our lives - body and soul - with Christ, and with His atoning work for all creation. It is the goal, the gift of heaven antecedently realized by an act of unspeakable grace and mercy.

The respect due to the Holy Mysteries is not atavistic or medieval. It is appropriate because of what, ie. Who, they are. The Kollyvades "push" for

more frequent communion was not intended to undermine that reverence or piety by turning communion into a free-for-all where anyone could partake regardless of their moral state, regardless of their preparation, regardless of their level of commitment, regardless of when they arrive for service, regardless of whether or not they have fasted. The pendulum has swung rather wildly - and perhaps somewhat excessively - in the other direction during the last 50 years or so. Priest Cassian Sibley

Can we lose grace?

Regarding loss of grace, I think the best way to approach it is to make sure we don't lose it! We know that God is more merciful than we can even imagine or that we are even capable of being ourselves. We also know that he is just and perfect. God will no doubt be perfectly merciful to every person that has ever been born because he made every person in His image to obtain His likeness.

I don't really think about things like this very much to be honest with you, because I think it's just a snare and a trap. My mind cannot comprehend God's mercy, so why should I try to decide if He will be merciful for this person or that person or because of this condition or that condition?

We should definitely fear sin because if we sin without repentance, we continue to sin, and we are lost. At what point we are lost, I do not know. I don't want to find out personally, either myself or anyone I love. This is the way I approach questions like this. God is perfectly merciful, and I cannot understand anything well. But I do know that God is merciful, and God will always help anyone who attempts to change. The story of the prodigal son makes that extremely apparent.

The loss of grace that Father Silouan (a Russian saint who died in the previous century and lived on Mount Athos) is talking about is not what you are talking about in your letter. Technically, we don't "lose grace." Grace is God's energy interacting with us. He gives it freely, and we, to put it crudely, "absorb it" to the extent that we are able. A person pure in heart, with no passions, can absorb much more grace than a person full of sins and darkness. What happens to us is sometimes we are very aware of God's grace working in us, and sometimes we are not aware. Sometimes this grace warms us and makes us glad, and sometimes we are full of dread or listlessness or some other sin. God does not abandon us, but we become

unaware of Him. So technically, we don't lose grace, but we become insensible to it.

There is a phenomenon that occurs especially among monastics or others who are great strugglers, of God's grace enlivening and energizing them to such an extent that they are, to paraphrase St. Paul's words, taken up to the third heaven, whether in the body are not in the body, they do not know. They become acutely aware of God's mercy and presence in their life, and they are very happy. This is a kind of ecstasy that may last for minutes or hours or even days or weeks, but everyone eventually loses the capability to have this feeling because we are still flesh and blood, dust and ashes. In the next life, this ecstasy will never end. These ecstasies may come back at various times, but we who are weak and still full of darkness should not flatter ourselves and think that we will be given ecstasy by God. We are not ready for that yet.

St. Silouan's life was unique in that he had an ecstatic experience very early in his life, and then for many years, he felt the loss of this grace acutely, or as I said above, he was aware that he was insensible to the presence of God in his life. Eventually, after great struggles, this experience returned to him. (Priest Seraphim)

The six-day creation.

What is the teaching on the six-day creation.? Is it literally six days or is it a number that represents the sequence of God's action? Also, has it been dogmatically defined.

I will begin answering your question by posing my own question. Are all questions important? Of course, we know that some questions are not as important as other questions. I think there are many theological questions that are not important. There are enough important theological questions that we should concentrate on them because getting them correct is absolutely necessary. I'm not saying this to shame anyone who asks any question. I've asked all of these kinds of questions. However, as I've gotten older, I learned that some questions take away our attention from the weightier matters.

My understanding has always been that the days in the Genesis creation story are not defined as 24-hour periods, nor are they defined as eons. There is a certain ambiguity about them. St. Basil the Great said regarding these "days", "Therefore, if you say a day or an aeon, you express the same meaning." (Basil the Great, Hex., Hom. II, 8). And since the Scripture tells us that to God: "One day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years are as one day." (2 Pe. 3:8), it does not seem particularly important to know for sure if the creation of the world occurred in six days of 24 hours as we know them, or over a longer period of time.

The most important aspect of understanding the creation story is that God did everything purposefully, and everything was perfect. He created the universe so that after doing so, He would create man in His own image and likeness so that we would always be with Him and always know Him.

I hope this answer is satisfactory to you. It's partly a non-answer to the question. We cannot know all things perfectly, not in this imperfect world. (Fr Seraphim)

Do we pray for non-Orthodox Christians?

The short answer is that we pray for everyone. The church prays for the entire world, including those who are not Orthodox Christians, those who believe in Christ but are not part of the church, those who are pagan, atheists, and those who oppose God and hate Him.

How should we pray for those who are not Orthodox? In many ways, certainly the most important ways, our private prayer for them should be just as intense and with just as much zeal and love as our prayer for those who are Orthodox. We can do prostrations for anyone at home; we can give alms for anyone; we can light a candle when we come to the church and pray for anyone privately.

You can pray for any person, alive or dead, Orthodox or not Orthodox, with the Jesus prayer. Simply say something like this: **"Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on (name)."** You can say this prayer once, or 3 times or as many times you wish.

Sometimes you want to pray more for a person because the person is very dear to us or we are particularly concerned about them. We may add prostrations if we want. Prostrations are very powerful. They are a way of involving our entire being in the prayer.

Perhaps you want to say a little bit more than just the Jesus prayer. I recommend that you use this prayer which I have taught many times.

To pray for someone more diligently:

From the Old Believer Prayer Book, with line 4,5 added

Save, O Lord, and have mercy on **Thy servant(s) _____**, [bow]
Deliver him (**her, them**) from every tribulation, wrath and need [bow],
From every sickness of soul and body, [bow]
Forgive him (**her, them**) every transgression, voluntary and involuntary, [bow]
Teach them to pray and to live with purpose. [bow]
And do whatever is profitable for our souls. [bow].

You may do this prayer with bows or with prostrations. You can pray for one particular person or any number of people. If you use the prayer often, you will soon memorize it, and it will be very comforting to you to use it.

Please note that the prayer has very general petitions. I do not recommend that you will pray a prayer like this: "O Lord, please help John to stop being an idiot and an alcoholic and a thief." We must be careful not to include the judgment of others in our prayer. If you are praying for someone who is an alcoholic, it is sufficient to ask that the Lord would have mercy on them. God knows what they need.

There are things that an Orthodox Christian should not do or request regarding prayer for those who are not Orthodox. For instance, we do not commemorate in church services non-orthodox Christians who have died. Of course, we pray for them in our homes. Can you imagine that if our mother or father dies, we would refuse to pray for them? Do we stop loving them? To stop loving someone is to defy the second greatest commandment. It is forbidden to stop loving someone, and if we love, we should naturally want to pray.

Because the church prays in her services for her children, we do not ask the church to pray for those who are not her children. Nor do we "convert" someone who has reposed. A person comes to the Orthodox church freely. If they have died outside of the church, then we must respect their decision. Because of love, we pray for them in our private prayers. If you have a loved one who died outside of the church, don't despair and don't think about it too much. Just love them, and pray for them. It is really that simple.

Regarding non-Orthodox Christians who are living, there are some who are very strict and do not pray for them in any church service, and there are others who will mention them in services such as molebens (that word actually means "prayer service"). I am one of those priests. I pray for people who are not Orthodox to get well or for any general need in moleben services. We can certainly pray for anyone in our private prayers at any time during a service. I recommend this!

It is our tradition not to commemorate non-orthodox in the proskimdie or at the Great Entrance. This is a time that the church reserves to pray for her children exclusively. When we commemorate someone in the proskimdie or preparation service, the priest takes a particle of bread and places it on to diskos. That bread represents the person we are praying for. All of that bread will be poured into the chalice after it has become the blood of Christ. Just as we respect the free will of someone who was died, we respect the free will of someone who is living. A person who is not

Orthodox does not receive Holy Communion from the church. Therefore, we do not commemorate them in the preparation service. However, most priests, including me, will pray privately for anybody during the preparation service. I just refrain from taking out any particles of bread.

Pray for ANYONE you may have harmed!

Also, say this prayer (below) every day. Twice a day would be better. People have harmed you, but you have also harmed other people. We must be humble and contrite about this. I say this prayer every day, and beg God to have mercy on me and not cause my sins to hurt others:

O Lord grant mercy unto them that bear hatred or enmity against me, and also unto them that revile or slander me: That none of them may at all suffer any evil, whether in the present or in the age to come, on account of me, who am impure. But cleanse them all in Thy mercy, and protect them by Thy grace, O Thou who art good. Old Believer Prayer Book, pg 312

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Holy Apostles Peter and Paul. What defines the ministry of the Apostles? The life of the Apostles and the church is built upon the bedrock of the confession of faith. Peter's confession. The 153 fish and the Restoration of Peter.

Matthew 16:13-19, John 21:15-25 2008

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Amen. Brothers and sisters, we celebrate the Apostles Peter and Paul today¹.

What is it that defines the ministry of the Apostles? The two Gospels show us. I want to speak about the first Gospel shortly and briefly because I think the matinal Gospel is much more powerful for our needs.

Today many people are thinking many things about Jesus, but Peter knew Who He was. He said, "Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God." The life of the Apostles is built upon the bedrock of their confession of faith.

To believe that Jesus is the Christ entails following His commandments because belief is not just a static thing; it is not just saying that we believe in a fact. It is dedicating ourselves. If we believe that Jesus is God, then we should obey Him. And the ministry of the Apostles was grounded in this fact.

Even while others were saying all kinds of things, He might be Elias, Jeremiah, a prophet, John the Baptist; Peter knew. And so the Lord said this famous part of the Scriptures where He says, Thou art Simon, "Thou art Peter, and upon this rock, I will build My church." The rock is the confession of Christ.

Now, in our day and age, especially in the West, the idea of confession of Christ is just BELIEF. No! It is LIVING according to the commandments because Jesus is God, and because He is reliable, and He showed us the way, and it is the only way to life.

So that is the first aspect of the Apostles -- and it should be of all the saints and us: the confession of Christ: to believe that Jesus is God, correctly, in every way - that means according to the Creed, according to the Seven Ecumenical Councils, according to the universal witness of the Church - Who Jesus is.

That's why it is so important to know Who He is. That's why it is so essential that in our services, over and over and over again, we speak dogmatically of the nature of God and of the two natures of Christ, and of what His resurrection entails and how He was a man and how He was God. All these things are said over and over again in our services. Because without knowing Christ, we will know nothing.

What is the application of this knowledge? What happened in the first Gospel, that is, the Gospel for matins last night², also happens to be a resurrectional Gospel, one of the eleven of the cycle³ and one of my favorites. It's truly breathtaking in its scope.

The Lord has appeared on the shore; the Apostles have seen Him. Peter is so excited to see Him, he throws his fisher's cloak on him, and he swims

to shore and the Lord. And then the Apostles follow, dragging the net full of fishes, one hundred fifty and three, and yet the net was not broken.

We could speak about that for a long time. This is very meaningful. The Apostles were prepared for their ministry over three years. Remember that before, more than three years ago, they, when they caught the fish, their nets broke. But after seasoning with the Lord, after learning of His ways and taking His yoke upon them, they were ready, so they could truly be fishers of men. And those 153 fish include us and all of humanity. Because regarding the Apostles: "Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth, and their words unto the ends of the world."⁴ So we are part of those fish.

Then Peter is on the shore with the Apostles, and they have eaten. And then the Lord says to Simon, "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou Me more than these?" He asks him, Do you love Me with a love that is above all things? Do you love Me as God loves and as we should love God? The word that He uses for "love" leaves no room for anything else. It is the love of God and a love for God⁵. Now, in Greek there are three words for love.⁶

Simon, only a few days before, remember, had rejected the Lord.⁷ He had denied Him three times. So he felt still shaky in his faith. He felt guilty. How would you feel? We'd feel guilty, right? We'd feel a sense of unworthiness.

So he says to the Lord, unsure of himself, he says, "I love You," but he used a different word⁸ - "I love you deeply, sincerely, as a friend, as a brother." And that is not how we should love God.

But the Lord said, afterward, "Feed My sheep." And then He repeated the same question identically, and identically Peter answered it again, and the Lord said, "Feed My lambs."

Now, the third time the Lord wants to teach Simon something and us too. He said, Simon, son of Jonas, do you love Me like a brother? Do you love me as a friend? Do you have a great affection for Me? He didn't say, "Do you love me as you would love God?". He used the same word for love that Simon had used the previous two times.

The Gospel says Peter was grieved because He said unto him the third time, Do you love me as a friend, as a brother, but not as God?"

And Simon said, "Lord, Thou knowest all things, Thou knowest that I love Thee."

Now, it is interesting to me also that at this point, Simon still uses the same word: I love you as a brother. But we know from his life that he loved Him as one would love God because we see the fruit of his life, the struggles that he went through. He was crucified for our Lord. We can see it in his epistles which have a striking clarity about the love of God and a

peacefulness about them that can only be from someone who loves God with a whole heart. But at that moment, Simon was still being prepared by the Lord. In time, he would show that he truly loved the Lord as one should love God.

What does this little vignette teach us? It teaches us that the apostles were called to love the Lord with all their heart, all their soul, all their mind, just as we are.

They weren't called any differently than we are. The extent of their ministry is different, but the base of their ministry, the reason for their ministry, is the same as us because they are responsible for the same commandments as we are. And they know the same God we know. But they loved the Lord with such power that it obliterated everything else.

And look at what they went through. The Apostle Paul gives a recounting of some of the things that happened to him. He was beaten with 40 stripes save one, five times. He was beaten with rods three times, shipwrecked three times. A day and a night, he was in the water. There were many other things - hunger and thirst and nakedness and wondering what would happen the next day, and fear and all the different gamut of human emotions that occur when we have arduous trials that we go through⁹. It was the same for the Apostle Paul, for the Apostle Peter, for John, James, all the rest.

This is what we are called to do - to love God such that we will feed the sheep. The Lord talks a lot about love for Himself, but He mostly talks about how we should love our neighbor. If you read the Gospels, they are mostly about how we should relate to other human beings. Why would this be?

Saint John makes it very clear. If we say we love God Whom we have not seen, and we don't love our brother whom we have seen, we are liars, and the truth of God is not within us¹⁰.

If we are Christians, we will love the brethren, and the brethren are everyone. Remember the parable about who is my neighbor?¹¹ Everybody is your neighbor: the mean ones, the kind ones, the honest ones, the thieves, the cruel, those who are good to you, those who are evil towards

you, those who speak badly of you, those who praise you, those who would give you back something of what you have done for them, those who would spit in your face and take more besides. All of those are the sheep.

There are many things, especially in our society; we seem to be a society that's created weaknesses, created passions. People have passions for television or smoking or video games; there are a hundred and fifty other things that we can become addicted to that many of our brethren from the earlier age were not tempted by because they had no access to these things. And there are still things you can be addicted to, for sure, but we have so many things in our society that it's very hard for us to pray, for us to be attentive.

And, yes, we should pray and be attentive. But here is the most essential thing that you should do. I've told you many times.

If you cannot stop sinning, at least be kind.

Love your brethren - that is the most important thing. It's more important to love your brethren - and that's everybody - rather than it is to pray or to fast. If we love the brethren, then we are showing love for God. Now, we must pray and fast, of course. But if we only pray and fast and do not love the brethren, we will not be saved.

Let us emulate the apostles, brothers, and sisters! Let us first confess Christ. It doesn't mean just saying I believe in Jesus Christ - it means living according to Who He is and what He taught. And let us, above all things, love Him so that we would, above all things, consider it our life's mission to feed the lambs and feed the sheep. May God grant us this blessed ministry. Amen.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2008 Transcribed by the hand of the handmaiden Helen (2011). May God save her and her loved ones.

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Feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul. *Exegesis of vespers Readings.* The Difference between Peter and Paul.

1 Peter 1:3-9 ; 1 Peter 1:13-19 ; 1 Peter 2:11-24

June 29 2011

In the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Today we read the epistles of Saint Peter. Tomorrow we will read the epistle of Saint Paul for the Feast of Saint Peter and Paul. They are very different because they came from different backgrounds. Of course, Peter was a fisherman. He was simple and was not highly educated. He was very forthright in how he wrote; he wrote simply and directly. There was always application to what he wrote.

Saint Paul was different. He was highly educated, highly intelligent, and much of what he wrote was very complicated to understand, and there is a great application in his teaching. But there is also a lot of very deep and difficult complex theology. You don't see that with Saint Peter.

What I see with Saint Peter, perhaps you do too. I see a very wise grandfather who has lived a good and long life and learned many of life's lessons, imparting his wisdom to his children and his grandchildren, and doesn't have to speak with citations and proofs. He speaks *with authority*, and he speaks *with experience*. This is the way that Saint Peter writes, and also the way that Saint John the Theologian writes as well.

If you look at the epistles of Peter, you will see that they are all about moral admonitions based upon what God has done for us, what Jesus Christ has done for us. He generally will give a moral admonition and say, "because of this", or might say something wonderful that God has done and then tell us what we should do.

This is the Christian life, and I would say that Saint Peter's epistles and Saint John's epistles, more than any of the other apostles or the other letters of the Scripture, have shaped my preaching because life is about *perfection*, and Saint Peter gets right to the point.

Saint Paul gives the groundwork, and it's very necessary to have that groundwork for the Church to be safe from heresy. But Saint Peter is like a holy grandfather sitting by the fire, perhaps, let's say, and teaching with authority from his life experience.

He begins his first letter, after giving a little bit of a salutation, "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ which according to His abundant mercy had begotten us again unto a liely hope by the Resurrection of Christ Jesus from the dead."¹²

And he goes on and says a few more things. And then what does he say? "Wherein ye greatly rejoiced. Though now for a season if need be are in heaviness through manifold temptations."

He knew what his flock was going through. They were going through periods of persecution. And even if there are not periods of persecution, perhaps we would say that we are not being persecuted now, although the Christian faith is being heavily persecuted worldwide, and it will come here soon, very soon; it's already coming in bits and pieces. Mostly it's political now and economical, but it will happen. Even if there is no direct persecution, there is heaviness because of the difficulties of life. But if we

are like Peter, we remember what God has done for us. We remember that He has given us a lively hope.

Lively. Our hope is not dead. Our hope is alive. Our hope is full of life. It is refreshing as the Holy Spirit refreshes as a wellspring of water. We should not forget this because there are times in our life that are difficult. We must remember, we were called to this lively hope, and because of this lively hope we will sometimes suffer.

At the end of this first reading, after speaking of asking his flock to endure because of this lively hope, he says, "Receiving the end of your faith even the salvation of your souls." This is the purpose of what we go through. *We should never forget it.*

We don't do things for no reason. Peter didn't do things for no reason. *The reason why he labored as an apostle was because of his great love for the Lord.*

Now, we didn't read this today, but the last one of the eleven resurrectional Gospels¹³ - have Peter prominently featured. The apostles fishing and then they brought the fish to land, and Peter had pulled the fish, a hundred and fifty and three, and though there were so many, the net was not broken, and then they sat down to eat.

And Jesus restored Peter by saying three times, "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou Me?"¹⁴ And He used the word for love that is the highest word possible, *agape*¹⁵, the love that God has for us and that we should have for God. And by extension, since we should love our neighbor as ourselves, and it is like the first Commandment, we should love our neighbor with this love. This is a pure love, an unselfish love. And each time of the first two that Jesus asked, Do you love Me with this love of God, Peter answered, I have *great affection*¹⁶ for Thee. This is a lower love, more of a human kind of love, certainly a good love to have, but not the love of God.

And the third time Jesus changed and says, Dost thee have *affection* for Me? And Peter was grieved, the Gospel tells us, because the third time the Lord changed the word. But Peter still didn't have courage enough to say that he loved God with a love that God has for us. So he answered the Lord three times: "I have affection for Thee."

But we see in the end of Peter's life when he writes his epistles, if the Lord were to ask him this question again, he would emphatically say, *Yea, Lord, I love Thee with the love that Thou has for me.* He loved the Lord with not just an affection or a great attachment, but a perfect love, because he was perfected by his trials.

He shares with us that there is another side to these trials. There is the perfection of our faith, the salvation of our souls. He speaks with experience. We should understand this. It means much more when you know some measure of man, the one who was timid about saying, "I love thee as Thou lovest me," and afraid to say it. But at the end of his life, he spoke with conviction. His epistles are permeated with great love for God. St. John's are the same way. There is this confidence, absolute knowledge of God's love, that permeates both of the writings of the Apostle John and the Apostle Peter.

In the second reading, he says, "Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, and be sober and hope to the end for the grace that is to be brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ."¹⁷

There are only a couple of sentences removed from the first reading in what we would call the first chapter. So he's again making a moral application. Girding up your loins means being ready, being ready to fight. Not to fight against man, but to fight; as the Lord said, the Kingdom of Heaven is being won by violence.¹⁸

It goes on to say, "As obedient children, not fashioning yourselves according to the former lusts in your ignorance: (15) But as he which hath called you is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation (conduct)"¹⁹

These words really resonate for me right now because I see a complete breakdown of morality that is happening in our society, and it is happening

even among those in the Church. As a pastor, I pay attention to certain mailing lists and, I'll tell you, it is frightening *how easily* people will say what is politically correct and believe it with all their heart. There are many that would believe that any type of sexual expression, if it is *supposedly* monogamous, is okay because it's about people loving one another. And of course, the Scripture recoils against this idea. Scripture recoils against lusts and fornication and certainly against unnatural sexual expression.

And yet there are many who do not experience the words of Saint Peter who believe the things that are said by our politicians, and they're swept away. We should not be like this.

There's only one way to avoid being swept away, brothers and sisters.

It's not by studying the Scriptures and making sure you know, what the Church teaches about this, this, and this; to know what they teach about sexuality, and know what they teach about fasting. No, these things by themselves are not going to help you.

Of course, you should know those things. I'm not against studying those things; I do - But what will help you is if you live with conviction as Saint Peter obviously did.

Then, in your heart, you *know what is right and what is wrong*, and it's obvious to you what lust is and what good desire is because God will reveal it to you just as He revealed it to Peter. So we must live in this way. You must, when you read the epistles of Peter - and I recommend that you do several times a year - understand that he is writing from conviction because of how he lived. He experienced it. We must experience this.

If Christians experienced holiness, they wouldn't be saying foolish things about monogamous relationships of an unnatural kind because they would understand in their heart about holiness.

This is very, very important.

This is how we fight the immorality of the age: By living in a moral way: By living with conviction.

Now, you see that Peter went through ups and downs. He made some serious errors. He denied our Lord three times, a very serious and grievous sin. But he had great strength of character. He did not abandon the Lord even after he had denied Him. And the Lord restored him.

So we can see that there is no sin that we could commit that the Lord will not restore us. But we must have an inner conviction in our heart about the Lord, that He is true, that only the things that He gives us have meaning and nothing else has meaning.

Then we will be able to read the epistles of Peter and have every word resonate with us and know that they are true, not because we say, "well, it's in the Bible and it's true." - but because we feel the resonance of the words from experience.

We must do this if we are to be saved, especially in this world now that is calling righteousness, sin; and sin, righteousness. And will eventually, I believe in my lifetime, it will be successful in large part, in calling righteousness mental illness.

We must be ready for this.

We must be ready by living a moral life, and then you will have conviction, and you will not believe the great lie because you will be living like Peter did - with conviction. This is how we must be.

The night is stretching on²⁰; it's getting late. I'd like to talk about the next epistle, but that is enough for now. Please, read the epistles of Peter with expectation that he would reach out to you because he can, and enlighten you with God being his helper and our helper, to know the truth by living it.

This is very, very important. Saint Paul is important too. Perhaps, overall, if one can actually say such a thing, Saint Paul perhaps is more important in keeping our theology intact, our dogmatic theology safe, because it was attacked in many places and many times by many robbers, and Saint Paul's writings were instrumental in protecting the church. Saint

Peter, though, has his place, as does Saint John. They write from authority because they lived in the way that they wrote. Of course, Saint Paul did too. But there is a different perspective.

So I recommend to you, if you can, tomorrow, read the epistles of Saint Peter with expectation.

The blessing of the Lord be upon you through His grace and love for mankind always now and ever and unto the ages of ages. Amen.²¹

Priest Seraphim Holland 2010. Transcribed by the hand of Helen; may the Lord save her and her loved ones.

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How Fr. Gervasios expelled a demon on Monday after Pentecost

Fr. Konstantinos, let me tell you the following important thing which has to do with a modern Saint, the revered and holy elder, Father Gervasios Paraskeupoulos of Patra.

Once, after the Holy Lent had finished and it was afternoon of the Sunday of Pascha. He performed the Liturgy and went to his room to eat his soup, made of just egg and lemon. The Afternoon of the Sunday of Pascha which had followed the Holy Lent involving a lot of asceticism and so on. He was eating his soup with a little cheese and half a red egg. This was his meal for that day.

A mother arrives, knocks his door and in tears begs the elder to help her with her daughter who had been possessed. "Come help her!" "Let it be blessed" says the elder. He finished his soup, took his stole ("epitrachelion") and the The Book of Prayers ("Euxologion") and they left.

The girl of a young age was at home inside a room, and she was possessed with a demon of terrible form. When the door of the house opened, the girl being inside the room shouts: "You [trago] priest, you come to expel me with your stomach full? No way I am leaving!" and was silent.

Fr. Gervasios and the mother listened to these words. The mother was so embarrassed and said: "My father please do not let these words insult you, my child is possessed!"

"I know, I know my child!"... "but let us not read the prayer today, let's come some other day to read the prayer!"

"Let it be blessed!" [said the mother]

The mother awaits, awaits... the Holy Pentecost arrives. After the Holy Pentecost, Sunday of the Holy Spirit, on Monday the door knocks and they

see a stretcher that was being held by four men. Lying on the stretcher was father Gervasios who was exhausted due to a 50 days fasting period.

He had completed the Lenten fast and then he went on to fast for another 50 days. "With your stomach full' right? I will show you!" the elder must have thought.

As soon as the demon possessing the girl smelled the smell of fast, tears and prayers of this holy man, what did he say? "I do not even want to see you! I am leaving, I am leaving, I am leaving... I do not even want to see you!" and he left and the child was set free.

The elder stood up and said with such humility: "My child, since the demon left, God sent him away, let us not read the prayer" and he did not read the prayer.

If only, they knew how many prayers the elder had offered for this soul! The elder did everything in his cell; who sacrifices [himself] for one soul?

"With your stomach full..." the demon said. Of course, the stomach of the elder was not full, the enemy was just "exaggerating" and offending him...

So, fasting helps in all issues... when we are called for "a greater surgery", we will do a certain fast along with noetic prayer and whatever God provides..." Edited, from the captions in : <https://youtu.be/x48jp-wxk3E>

Holy Elder Justin (Pârvu) of Romania on freedom.

"Freedom becomes precious only when it is lost. Or at least, this is how we think. All his life man seeks to be free, but does not appreciate the gift of his freedom until it is too late. Freedom is in our body but also in our heart. Freedom is in action, but also in the mind and the intellect. Man is free by how genuinely he loves and is attached to the values of the faith.

We are free when we accept God's plan for our life and when we strive to achieve it. Being free does not mean lethargy and bliss, but the fulfillment of your human condition.

Freedom does not mean to do what I always wish, as many times by doing what I like I do the will of the devil. Freedom is at the measure of

man's discernment, and his capacity to choose between good and evil.

Man must realize that only in Truth he can live freely and with so much confusion in this world, he should avoid deception. It was what Communists did not understand, that only on the Cross the human soul gains true freedom, that all their methods of torture and psychological pressure to re-educate us, have made more saints than slaves, have sanctified our land by the martyrs' blood.

Freedom is hard to understand when one has not lived in those times [of persecution], and our Christians today barely reflect of this past."

Q: What is a parent to do when they find out their child has gone astray?

+Saint Paisios of Athos: "Even the most serious fall of the children shouldn't make parents desperate, for sin has become fashionable in our time. They should always keep in mind the following: Nowadays, young people will be granted certain "extenuating circumstances" and will be judged with leniency for their transgressions. Today a grade of "seven" for conduct is the equivalent to the "ten" – "excellent" of our schooldays. Of course, parents will always try to help their children, but they mustn't be overly anxious. Children will get more sensible and experienced with time.

Right now they may not understand what is good because their mind has not yet matured. Their mind is cloudy, and it lacks clarity to discern the danger that lies ahead and the irreparable damage they can suffer."

Hieromonk Kosmas in Australia says that St Paisios gave a ten for a seven but this was back in the 80s or 90s (depending on when he said it before his repose), but this has only become even greater nowadays as the world continues to be swarmed by passions. HM Kosmas says a "2" nowadays is worth a "10" back then.

So do not be hard on your children! Love them and pray for them. The enemies of Christians are roaring lions, or multi-headed hydras waiting to

devour us. Lord, have mercy.

THE PRIEST IS THE DONKEY ON WHICH CHRIST RIDES.

I have a good friend, Archpriest Nicholas. Just thinking about him makes my heart feel good. Although we have not seen each other for many years, every day, I pray for him as one of my relatives, and I still remember our old meeting.

Things were getting worse than ever; I had dropped out of university, I had left my girlfriend, I had no job, no one needed me, and I didn't know what to do. I came to the nearest church because I had nowhere else to go. I met Fr. Nicholas at confession. I simply walked up to the first priest I saw and told him about my misguided life.

It was the first time in my life that a priest had ever cried over me. He just stood there with his head down and cried his eyes out. And then very insistently asked me to go to church. That's right - he did. Not to instruct, not to point, but to ask.

That's how we met.

After confession, Father Nicholas asks: "Do you have a passport? Come with us to Moscow!" With us is a group of children from the parish and their entourage.

Everything happened as if in a dream. Father Nicholas leads me to some people and says, "Take his passport and buy a ticket. He is coming

with us." He shoved my passport and smiled at me beamingly. So I found myself at the Trinity-Sergius Lavra and many of Moscow's shrines.

On the way back on the train father Nicholas came up to me, gave me a hug and suddenly I had money in my hand. He quickly hid his hands behind his back and said: "Take it, take it! You need it for the first time! I'm not taking it back anyway!" And he got out of the compartment.

He was a stranger, and not close to me, who just could not pass by, when someone feels bad. Then we went together to visit Father Nikolai Guryanov in Zalit and many other places, but I will never forget that first meeting we had. And I will tell my children about it.

Some people will wag their finger at this story, and some will say, "The priests are getting greedy! But for that lost guy, soaked under the cold autumn rain, it was the roar of the Archangel trumpet from Paradise, from which he woke up, stood up and at first uncertainly, but went toward the light and God, Whom in that skinny little priest he had met. I still remember his words about his priestly ministry: **"A priest is the donkey on which Christ rides.** Denis Akhalashvili.

[Orthodox Parables and Stories](#)

Elder Cleopa: Lay people can surpass monks!

Elder Cleopa told the following story about an incident that occurred in the church of Sihastria:

"In the winter of 1971 it was my turn to serve at the Holy Altar. I came to the church at four in the morning to say my prayers before Holy Communion in front of the Holy Table. After not much time had passed, a woman entered to pray. She had come to the monastery the previous evening. I did not know her. She prayed slowly before all the icons and was constantly making prostrations. She did not know that there was someone else in the church, since it was dark, being wintertime. Seeing that she was praying so diligently, I looked through the Holy Doors to see who was praying with so much faith. The woman was on her knees in the middle of the church with her hands raised and was saying from her whole heart these words: 'Lord, do not leave me! Lord, do not leave me!'

"Then I saw a yellowish light around her head, and it frightened me terribly. The woman fell with her face to the ground and prayed voicelessly. The ray of light above her became bigger and rose above her head. After a little time the light slowly went out. The woman got up and went out of the church. It was a peasant woman.

"Behold who has the gift of prayer! Behold, lay people surpass us monks! I had finished Proskomedia, and with great feeling, I began to weep with the Spear in my hand. Only God knows how many chosen ones there are in the world!"

Elder Cleopa of Sihastria, Shepherd of Souls: The Life and Teachings of Elder Cleopa Master of Inner Prayer and Spiritual Father of Romania (1912 – 1998)

St. Mark Ji Tianxiang couldn't stay sober, but he could keep showing up.

St. Mark Ji Tianxiang was an opium addict. Not *had been* an opium addict. He *was* an opium addict at the time of his death.

For years, Ji was a respectable Christian, raised in a Christian family in 19th-century China. He was a leader in the Christian community, a well-off doctor who served the poor for free. But he became ill with a violent stomach ailment and treated himself with opium. It was a perfectly reasonable thing to do, but Ji soon became addicted to the drug, an addiction that was considered shameful and gravely scandalous.

As his circumstances deteriorated, Ji continued to fight his addiction. He frequently went to confession, refusing to embrace this affliction that had taken control of him. Unfortunately, the priest to whom he confessed (along with nearly everybody in the 19th century) didn't understand addiction as a disease. Since Ji kept confessing the same sin, the priest thought, that was evidence that he had no firm purpose of amendment, no desire to do better.

Without resolve to repent and sin no more, confession is invalid. After a few years, Ji's confessor told him to stop coming back until he could fulfill the requirements for confession. For some, this might have been an invitation to leave the Church in anger or shame, but for all his fallenness, Ji

knew himself to be loved by the Father and by the Church. He knew that the Lord wanted his heart, even if he couldn't manage to give over his life. He couldn't stay sober, but he could keep showing up.

And show up he did, for 30 years. For 30 years, he was unable to receive the sacraments. And for 30 years, he prayed that he would die a martyr. It seemed to Ji that the only way he could be saved was through a martyr's crown.

In 1900, when the Boxer Rebels began to turn against foreigners and Christians, Ji got his chance. He was rounded up with dozens of other Christians, including his son, six grandchildren, and two daughters-in-law. Many of those imprisoned with him were likely disgusted by his presence there among them, this man who couldn't go a day without a hit. Surely he would be the first to deny the Lord.

But while Ji was never able to beat his addiction, he was, in the end, flooded with the grace of final perseverance. No threat could shake him; no torture make him waver. He was determined to follow the Lord, who had never abandoned him.

As Ji and his family were dragged to prison to await their execution, his grandson looked fearfully at him. "Grandpa, where are we going?" he asked. "We're going home," came the answer.

Ji begged his captors to kill him last so that none of his family would have to die alone. He stood beside all nine of them as they were beheaded. In the end, he went to his death singing the Litany of the Blessed Virgin Mary. And though he had been away from the sacraments for decades, he is a canonized saint.

St. Mark Ji Tianxiang is a beautiful witness to the grace of God constantly at work in the most hidden ways, to God's ability to make great saints of the most unlikely among us, and to the grace poured out on those who remain faithful when it seems even the Church herself is driving them away.

On July 9, the feast of St. Mark Ji Tianxiang, let's ask his intercession for all addicts and for all those who are unable to receive the sacraments, that they may have the courage to be faithful to the Church and that they may always grow in their love for and trust in the Lord. St. Mark Ji Tianxiang, pray for us!

<https://aleteia.org/2017/07/06/he-was-an-opium-addict-who-couldnt-receive-the-sacraments-but-hes-a-martyr-and-a-saint/>

Can Tea and Bricks Be More Important than The Jesus Prayer? A Story Told by Elder Paisios of The Holy Mountain

"When in 1953 I came to the Esphigmenou monastery, as a novice, I was assigned to help in the refectory.

Once an old and quite decrepit monk in his eighties asked me to sometimes bring soup to his cell for him, and so, finishing my obedience, I would pour some soup into a bowl and bring it to him.

There was a brother there who didn't like it. Once he saw me pour the soup and started his broken record, 'Listen, don't accustom him to pampered life. He'll get used to it and start nagging at you asking for one thing after another. You will end up spending all your time with this old man until you don't have any left to keep your monastic prayer rule. You should have seen him torture me with his requests! I only helped him once when he caught a cold, and he just wouldn't leave me alone. He kept knocking on my wall with his 'Show me love and make me some tea' or 'Show me love and help me turn over on the other side'. And then again in a few minutes: knock-knock, 'Show love and put a hot brick on my lower back'... And he just went on and on like, 'Pour me some tea, give me a brick'... 'Give me a brick, pour me some tea'. But I have to pray, how about

that?.. I have my prayer rule!.. When am I supposed to do it if this old man keeps driving me bananas?..'

Can you imagine this nightmare? I can't wrap my head around it! An old man is suffering and groaning behind the wall asking a monk for help, but the monk says 'no' because he does not want to interrupt his prayer rule!

This is a sign of a completely icy, soulless state.

What doubts can there be when it is clear as day that these bricks and tea would be of much greater importance for God than any possible number of 'perfect' bows and prayers!

After all, standing with his rosary before Christ, that monk asked Him, 'Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me' while snapping at his suffering neighbor".

<https://blog.obitel-minsk.com/2021/06/can-tea-and-bricks-be-more-important-than-the-jesus-prayer-a-story-told-by-elder-paisios-of-the-holy-mountain.html>

Translated by The Catalogue of Good Deeds

Source: <https://zen.yandex.ru/media/orfograf/moqut-li-chai-i-kirpich-byt-vajnee-molitvy-iisusovi-otvechaet-sviatoi-starec-paisii-sviatogorec-601402af7fd0a5390f2c8e42>

St. PAISIOS ON ECUMENISM, SCHISM, AND SPIRITUAL DISCERNMENT

"It appears he (Patriarch Athenagoras [The Patriarch of Constantinople from 1948–1972; the current incumbent is Bartholomew since 1991 – both are avowed ecumenists who have continually spoken glowingly about the Latins and ecumenism in general – fs]) loved another modern woman—which is called the Papist Church—because our Orthodox Mother has not made an impression on him at all, for She is so modest. This love, which was heard from Constantinople, caused a sensational impression of sorts among many Orthodox, who nowadays live in an environment of such meaningless love, in cities across the entire world. Moreover, this love is of the spirit of our age: the family will lose its divine meaning from just such kinds of love, which have as their aim breakup and not union.

With just such a worldly love, the Patriarch takes us to Rome. While he should have shown love first to us his children, and to our Mother Church, he, unfortunately, sent his love very far away. The result, it's true, delighted the secular children who love the world—who have this worldly love—, but completely scandalized us, the children of Orthodoxy, young and old, who have fear of God...

With sadness I must write that among all the "unionists" I've met, never have I seen them to have either a drop or shred of spirituality. Nevertheless, they know how to speak about love and union while they themselves are not united with God, for they have not loved Him.

I would like tenderly to beseech all our unionist brothers: Since the issue of the union of the Churches is something spiritual, and we have need of spiritual love, let's leave it to those who greatly love God and are [genuine] theologians, like the Fathers of the Church—not the legalists—

who have offered up and continue to give themselves in service to the Church (instead of just buying big candles), and who were and are lit by the fire of love for God rather than by the lighter of the church sacristan...

We should recognize that there exist not only natural but also spiritual laws. Therefore, the future wrath of God is not averted by a convocation of sinners (for then we shall receive double the wrath), but by repentance and adherence to the commandments of the Lord.

Also, we should know well that our Orthodox Church does not have even one shortcoming. The only apparent insufficiency is the shortage of sober Hierarchs and Shepherds with a Patristic foundation. "Few are chosen." This should not, however be upsetting. The Church is Christ's Church, and He governs Her. It is not a Temple built by the pious from rocks, sand and mortar, which is then destroyed by the fire of barbarians; the Church is Christ Himself. "And whosoever shall fall on this Stone shall be broken: but on whomsoever it shall fall, it will grind him to powder." (Matt. 21:44-45)

When He must needs, the Lord will bring forth the Mark of Ephesuses and Gregory Palamas, so as to bring together all our scandalized brethren, to confess the Orthodox Faith, to strengthen the Tradition, and to give great joy to our Mother, the Church.

In times past we see that many faithful children of our Church, monastics and laymen, have unfortunately broken away from Her on account of the unionists. In my opinion, separation from the Church each time the Patriarch makes a mistake is not good at all. From within, close to the Mother Church, it is the duty and obligation of each member to

struggle in their own way. To cease commemoration of the Patriarch; to break away and create their own Church; and to continue to speak insultingly to the Patriarch: this I think, is senseless.

If, for this or that occasional deviation of the Patriarchs, we separate ourselves and make our own Churches—may God protect us!—we'll pass up even the Protestants. It is easy for one to separate but difficult to return. Unfortunately we have many "churches" in our times, created either by big groups or even just one person. Because there happened to be a church in their kalyve (I am speaking about things happening on the Holy Mountain), they figured they could create their own independent Church.

If the unionists gave the Church the first wound, the aforementioned give the second.

Let's pray that God will illumine all of us, including our Patriarch Athenagoras, that union of these "churches" will come about first; that tranquility would be realized within the scandalized Orthodox fold; so that peace and love would exist among the Eastern Orthodox Churches. Then let's think about union with other "Confessions"—and only if they sincerely desire to embrace Orthodox Dogma.

I would further like to say that there does exist another, third group, within our Church. They are the brethren who remain as Her faithful

children, but who don't have spiritual concord between themselves. They spend their time criticizing one another, and not for the general good of the struggle. The one monitors the other (more than himself) to see what he will say or write so as to ruthlessly nail him. However, if this person had said or written the same thing, he'd certainly have supported it with numerous passages from the Holy Scriptures and the Fathers.

Great harm comes of this; for while the one injures his neighbor, the other strikes him back before the eyes of all the faithful. Often times, disbelief is sown in the souls of the weak, because they are scandalized by such people. Unfortunately, some from among us make senseless claims against the others. We want them to conform to our own spiritual character. In other words, when someone else doesn't harmonize with our own character, or is only mildly tolerant—or even a little sharp—with us, immediately we jump to the conclusion that he is not a spiritual person.

We're all needed within the Church. All the Fathers, both the mild and the austere, offered their services to Her. Just as the sweet, sour, bitter and even pungent herbs are necessary for a man's body (each has its own flavor and vitamins), the same is true of the Body of the Church. All are necessary. The one fills up the spiritual character of the other, and all of us are duty bound to endure not only the particular spiritual character, but even the human weaknesses we each have."

Marriage to a Non-believer?

"Contemporary people, even when they come to the Church, do not wish to genuinely change their mindset. They do not wish to genuinely repent (for 'repentance' in the biblical sense is a change of mindset). They want at once to be both Orthodox and friends of this world. People have absolutely no desire to make this choice, and so they begin to want to 'sanctify everything.' This gives rise to the invention of new virtues, foreign to the holy fathers (such as 'tolerance of spiritual delusion'). The old terms, such as 'love' and 'marriage', take on entirely new meanings. And we begin to encounter the opinion that since there are many 'good' or 'nice' people outside the Church, Christianity isn't something they really need after all. Christianity becomes something that is desirable but not essential.

This is more true given that their goals in life are frequently identical -- comfort and convenience at all costs, deification of culture etc. They even share the same attitude towards childbearing. Is it not common knowledge that a great many seemingly 'Christian' women react to a positive pregnancy test as little better than a diagnosis of cancer? And this despite the fact that they go to church, and every service hear the commemoration of 'the ancestors of God Joachim and Anna.' The truth is that their chief god is money and comfort."

-- Hieromartyr Daniel Sysoev +2009, 'Marriage to a Non-believer?'

The wisdom of withholding judgement

I have helped a few people, some for many years. After twenty years, one of them came out and called me a villain. I will not argue with him - he was right. Yet a small part of me was still saying, "Have I cared for that person all these years to hear him call me a villain?" Instead, I should have humbled myself and said, without reservation, *"Thank you for reminding me who I am."* Saying so honestly and full-heartedly would have been an inner victory.

Yet, most people in similar situations would feel embittered. Typically, they would respond, *"I hear it from a villain. Look at you! Who are you to judge me? You ungrateful swine!"* At the Convent, I always remind myself not to criticize others, for criticism can make enemies. Especially in people who are not prepared to take it.

It is the same way in a family. Most of us are not prepared to hear the truth about ourselves. Crack the truth to someone who is not ready for it, and you will only make him bitter. Nothing good will result from this truth-telling. Christians should be wise and think hard before taking action. They may see all kinds of people not perform at their best. Their superiors and even bishop and metropolitans can be sinners. Yet sin is an affliction, and we do not judge sinners but pray for them. At some moments, they may not have God's spirit and may not speak from God. We do not denounce

them but give them more of our love. For many years, some of our brothers have been called rejects from hell and good for nothing. They have heard it so often that they have become used to it. Yet say to someone, *"You are kind, and generous, and beautiful"*, and you may begin to see a change.

Apostle Paul tells us that we are all a temple of God. Can you imagine that? Do you not find that somewhat hard to believe? But what if he is right? What if we are truly temples of God? What if we have God's spirit in us, and we can clean this temple from all the clutter and waste that often piles up quickly and burdens our immortal soul?

Let us imagine ourselves for a minute as saints entering the Kingdom of Heaven. What are we going to do there? I sometimes hear this question from the brothers at the farmstead, and I give them this example. *"There will be no cigarettes there. Many of you die without a smoke. You had better quit smoking by the time you get there."* So what will the Kingdom of God be like for us? God makes it very clear to everyone: your life in the Kingdom of God will be a reflection of your present life. If you are living in God, fully and sincerely, you will be at home there.

Never criticize your loved ones unwisely. Never say to your children that you are ashamed of them. Do not ever say such things to any of your kin. Do not leave them to feel embittered for the rest of their lives, and

The life of CONON, a presbyter of the monastery of Penthucula.

When we visited abba Athanasius in the monastery of our holy father Saba he told us of an Alexandrian presbyter called Conon who was in charge of Baptisms. The fathers had decreed that the high quality of his character made him worthy of baptising those who came seeking for it. So he anointed with the holy Chrism and baptized those who came. But whenever he had to anoint a woman he became so agitated [in those days, all were baptized and anointed naked – fs] that he wanted to leave the monastery. While battling with this thought the holy John Baptist appeared to him, saying: "Endure, and persevere and I will lift this burden from you."

One day an attractive young Persian woman came to be baptized who was so beautiful that the presbyter could not bring himself to anoint her bare flesh with oil. When Archbishop Peter heard that the girl had already been there two days he was exceedingly angry with the old man, and even wanted to delegate this ministry to a deaconess, but refrained from doing so as he did not want to be seen to be doing anything contrary to the canons. But Conon the presbyter took his cloak and went, saying that he would not remain any longer in that place. He had got as far as the hills, when behold, the holy John Baptist met him in the way and spoke to him gently, saying: "Go back to your monastery and I will lift this battle from you."

"I certainly will not go back," replied Abba Conon indignantly. "You have so often made these promises and not fulfilled them."

Then the holy John made him sit down and take off his clothes. He made the sign of the cross three times on his navel and said: "Believe me, presbyter Conon, I had been hoping that you would have been able to receive a reward because of this battle. As it is, however, look, I have taken this battle away from you, but you have forfeited any reward."

The presbyter returned to the cenobium, to take up once more his baptismal ministry. The next day he anointed and baptised the young woman, hardly even noticing that she was, in fact, a woman. He continued the ministry of baptism for another twelve years in such tranquillity of mind and body that he never experienced any excitement of the flesh, nor consciously thought of anyone specifically as a woman. And so in peace he lived out his days. (From: The Spiritual Meadow of St John Moschus. <http://www.vitae-patrum.org.uk/page141.html>)

I have known people that want to run away from situations where they feel that they have trouble with uncleanness. But that does not mean that we can quit a job and be without work, just because there might be someone who says unclean things in the job or perhaps there are unclean

posters in various places in the job. Of course, there are places that we should flee from – I would not recommend that an alcoholic work in a bar or a person with impurity live near a whorehouse, but we are called to struggle against our sexual passions and all other passions. Many times, it is not pleasing to God that we decide to struggle against our passion by running away from something. Many times, God wants us to struggle. Our crown is from the struggle, and not in the success. The success from our struggle comes when God chooses to completely help us regarding our weakness. When we struggle and we fail, we are humbled, and God will always give his grace to us when we are humbled.

I have a funny story, or at least it is to me, regarding impure pictures at work. A long time ago in a galaxy far away I was a computer programmer, and I worked contracts. One of the contracts was at Anheuser-Busch. Everybody in their cubicles had all the beer posters up, and there was an endless supply of them. You know the posters I'm referring to, with all of the buxom women in bikinis and such. I didn't have anything on my walls because I wasn't about to put that stuff up. People around me didn't like that, so they put beer girls up for me. I took them down, and they put them back up. So, I went to the store and bought big posters of lions and tigers. Once I put those up, they never bothered me again.

Another story from that era. Sometimes in offices people just stand around and talk for a little while and they should be working. I did that too, but I would always leave the group whenever they started to tell dirty jokes. I didn't say anything, I just walked away and went back to my desk. I think I developed a little bit of a reputation, and they must've decided they wanted to do something to embarrass me. We would go to lunch together, usually once a week. One week they decided they were going to go to "Hooters". Now this is before the Internet was popular, and I didn't know what "Hooters" was. I literally thought that it was a restaurant that had a picture of an owl as it's mascot. It's not that I didn't know that part of their title was actually a slang word, but it never occurred to me that the restaurant had anything to do with anything except a picture of an owl. We were getting ready to go, and I saw everybody in acting conspiratorial and I thought something's not right. So, I begged off and said I had work to do. Later on, I found out what "Hooters" really was. I've never been in one of those kinds of restaurants and I never plan to be. (Priest Seraphim Holland)

"I AM A MONK, FIRST AND FOREMOST" An Interview with the Ukrainian Primate

—Your Beatitude, how can we learn to love our enemies, and what is true Christian love?

—To [love our enemies](#), we must first love God. What is love of God? It is the fulfillment of the Divine laws. The Lord said: *If ye love Me, keep My commandments* (Jn. 14:15). Love doesn't choose which of the commandments to fulfill and which not. If we want to know whether or not we love God, we have to see whether or not we are keeping God's laws. Love of God is the first and most important commandment, and the second is like unto it—love of others. But if there is no love for God, then there is no love for others, because love of others should be like our love of God. But if we don't have any, then what will our love for man be like? Like some kind of caricature. When someone doesn't love God, but says he loves others, he deceives himself and all those around him. And if we love someone without God, that is, not loving God, then our love is commercial.

We do good for someone because we expect he'll do the same for us one day, or because he's our relative, or because he's our friend—that is, we always expect some kind of recompense for this love. True love is sacrificial love. It destroys evil and elevates us above the minutiae of everyday life, and for someone who has achieved this kind of love, it's quite easy to love his enemies.

—How can we maintain ourselves in spiritual purity?

—All of us mortals—those who lived before us, those who are alive today, and those who will live after us—are sinners. Some of us have great sins, some have lesser sins, some have minor sins; but every person has sin, which hinders him in seeing God in His glory. Every person, even the most sinful, if he is attentive to himself and everything going on in the world, will see the power and might of God. But if we want to see God not just in power, but also in glory, then we must especially try to follow Christ during

our earthly life and repent and amend our ways. We must seek Christ by fulfilling the Divine commandments. If I haven't found Christ yet, I will search for Him; if I have found Him, I will follow Him and come to know His will and do it. Only thus are we vouchsafed to see the Lord in glory, face-to-face, with the eyes of our heart—it is possible only with a pure heart. Every man should try to follow Christ with his life in order to see Him with the eyes of his heart. Then we will be accounted worthy to see Christ with our bodily eyes as well in His Heavenly Kingdom.

—What is the image of a true Christian for you?

—A true Christian is someone who is able to be transformed and who desires it. Everyone bears the image of God within himself. To be transfigured means to reveal this image, to liberate it from sin, from pride, from envy and anger, from every impurity, from cruelty, and to show the Divine beauty that every man bears within himself. How do we do this? We must ascend Mt. Tabor—that is, tear ourselves away from the earth, from purely earthly interests, and gradually rise above them. This can be done with the help of prayer and repentance. Rising from the earthly to the Heavenly by faith, we must pray and perfect Divine hope and Divine love within ourselves. The Apostles before whom the Lord was transfigured teach us this: The Apostle Peter is a type of faith, the Apostle James a type of hope, and the Apostle John is a type of love. Every man has his own character, his own temper, his own behavior and individual characteristics. But every man bears the Divine image, which is beautiful and noble. It is the adornment that makes a man a true man. When a man takes care to ascend Mt. Tabor, to where the Lord can be found is His glory, then he is a true Christian.

—What has been the most difficult part of your ministry as the primate of the Church? And what is the most important part?

Elder Paisios and St. Euphemia

“Father Paisios was going through a very difficult time. At that time a problem had arisen in the Church and many bishops had gone to him asking for his help. However, it was a very complicated problem and even if he wanted to, he was unable to help them. As he himself said, no matter from which angle you look at the problem, you come face to face with a spiritual impasse. So, he decided to turn his efforts in solving the problem into prayer. Father Paisios constantly prayed for God to give a solution to the Church's problem; he prayed especially to St. Ephemia:

“St. Euphemia, you who miraculously gave a solution to the serious problem the Church was facing in the fourth century, take the Church out of its current difficulty!”

One morning, at nine o' clock, when Father Paisios was reading the service of the third hour, he suddenly heard someone discreetly knocking on his door. The Elder asked: “Who is it?”

Then, he heard a woman's voice answering: “It is me, Euphemia, Father.”

“Which Euphemia?” he asked.

There was no answer. There was another knock on the door and again he asked: “Who is it?”

The same voice was heard saying: “It is Euphemia, Father.”

There was a third knock and the Elder felt someone coming inside his cell and walking through the corridor. He went to the door and there he saw St. Euphemia, who had miraculously entered his cell through the locked door and was venerating the icon of the Holy Trinity, which the Elder had placed on the wall of his corridor, on the right hand side of the church's door.

Then the Elder told the saint: “Say: Glory to the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit.”

—I am a monk, first and foremost, and I accept this position as another Church obedience, of which there have been many in my life. Any ministry of a monk is the fulfillment of an obedience. There are various obediences—prospora, the kliros, trapeza, celebrating the services, the episcopal ministry. Our task is to force ourselves to follow the Lord's commandments and fulfill them. First of all—and this is the most important—we have to force ourselves to pray humbly, to give ourselves over to the will of God and hope not in ourselves, but in God, Who raises the dead. We have to try to lead our lives so our eyes and our thoughts would be ever directed to God; then we will see that our entire life is filled with His presence and His all-encompassing grace.

I want the spiritual life of every priest and layperson of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church to change for the better while the Lord keeps me in this obedience. This spiritual growth is achieved through prayer; a Christian must force himself to the *podvig* of prayer, each according to his strength. It is the stimulus that gives man the power to rise above; thanks to prayer, we can achieve humility, and patience, and love.

I consider my second important task to be to establish closer contacts between the clergy and the people. Virtual communication is fashionable today; that is, communication in which the facilitator is a conditional, artificial, or, as its also called, virtual world. This artificial intermediary separates man from the real world, not giving him the chance to understand true reality. In live, real communication, we find the truth that the virtual world does not give, which is a dead layer of padding, and can present the virtues as shortcomings, and vice versa. Therefore, the clergy should communicate with their flock in the real world, with direct face-to-face contact. This will give them the chance to properly understand a man's problems and help him cope with them. [Metropolitan Onuphry of Kiev and All Ukraine](#), Translation by Jesse Dominick, 11/30/2020, [Information-Education Department of the UOC](#)

St. Euphemia clearly repeated those words and immediately Father Paisios knelt and venerated her.

Afterwards, they sat and talked for quite a while; he could not specify for how long, as he had lost all sense of time while being in the presence of the saint. She gave the solution for all three matters he had been praying about.

In the end he said to her: “I would like you to tell me how you endured your martyrdom.”

The saint replied: “Father, if I knew back then how eternal life would be, and the heavenly beauty souls close to God enjoy, I honestly would have asked for my martyrdom to last for ever, as it was absolutely nothing compared to God's gifts of grace!”

“Towards the end of June, the doctors informed [Elder Paisios] that he had about 2-3 weeks left. On Monday, July 11, on St. Ephemia's day, Father Paisios received Holy Communion for the last time, kneeling in front of his bed. During the last 24 hours, he was very serene, and even though he suffered, he did not complain at all. He did not wish to take any more medication. The only medicine he accepted was cortisone, because, according to the doctors, it would not prolong his life span, but it would only give him some strength. On Tuesday, July 12, Elder Paisios humbly and peacefully rendered his soul to God, whom he had deeply loved and served since his early childhood.”

May Saint Paisios continue to pray fervently for our wretched souls!

WHY IS IT SO HARD NOWADAYS TO PRAY? (Fr. Rafail Noica)

Fr. Sophrony mentioned this many times: "If you want to pray, know that you are like a molecule of water in a frozen ocean, a molecule that does not want to freeze together with the ocean. In nature, this is impossible. Don't forget what I have told you, so you don't lose your salvation!"

That's what he [St. Sophrony Sakharov] said, several times. I think he meant, "So you don't lose your salvation by despairing."

What is the frozen ocean? The world we are in.

Who is still praying [for real] today? Yesterday I passed through the city a bit, I got depressed to see the world we are in. Well, "depressed", it's just a way of saying... It's such a "cold" world, so foreign to God, so full of vain ideals. And we, each of us (Fr. Sophrony was talking not only about a molecule in an ocean) are part of the huge Adamic tree whose sap nourishes us all. We are nourished by the sap that flows through this tree, today it is a poisoned sap, the sap of unbelief, the sap of hate for God. See the TV programs that always mock the Church and find reasons to make a fuss and so on.

This is the New Age we are in. If I am a branch of this tree, how can I focus when the whole world is looking elsewhere? To some extent I can, but this measure is the extent to which I can get some help from God, from the grace of God. Until then, however, I am in this endless struggle, and the only thing I could say is what Father Cleopa [Ilie] said: "Patience, patience,

patience... and when you feel you can no longer stand, then: patience, patience, patience..."

And do not despair, go ahead, because in the God's Book of Life there are inscribed not only our successes, which are not ours after all, ours is the choice, the success is His in us, but in the Book of Life are inscribed all our seemingly useless efforts, when we think we don't succeed... So "Keep your mind in hell and despair not"... yes, we are in this world... But let's think like this: **if God allowed me to be in this world, or if God was willing for me to be in this devilish world, it means I can still be saved.**

What do I rely on when I say this? Christ said in chapter 13 of St. Mark, I paraphrase a little, "When no one could be saved any longer, the Father will shorten those days." If these days have not been shortened yet and my children and I have entered this world, we can still be saved, somehow... But in the meantime: patience, patience, patience!

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cJKcM3IRuWs>

Weeping at night

We must weep at night to feel joy in the day.
We cannot know the Man of Sorrows if we do not weep at night.
Everything in the world is corrupting and will pass away
- even those things that bring us apparent joy.
There is only one eternal joy.
If we weep at night, sometimes we will feel part of that joy.
The cold world does not know joy.
Entertainment brings not joy.
Indulging desires brings not joy.
Fulfilling ambitions brings not joy.
Only Christ brings joy.

He will come to us and abide in us, but only if we make room for Him.
There is no room with earthly joy.

Only sorrow, weeping and repentance will make room for joy.
Do not weep when in the world, among those of the world.
Observe the world with your heart, and if you have made room, you will see the hidden reality in life.
Save those things in your heart for the evening, when you will weep.
This weeping is dear to God; He hears all who weep to Him.

By Priest Seraphim. My words were inspired by a favorite passage in "Everyday Saints". A wise monk commented about a morose novice, something like this: "He does not cry enough at night".

Fighting Thoughts

Thoughts come and go. They are like the wind. It is very hard to control them. **The most critical thing we must do regarding thoughts is to resist them.** We cannot always stop them, but we can resist them. Even if we do not do so well in this, the Lord sees our effort, and He will help us.

Make sure to never "own" your thoughts. I mean that your thoughts are not who you are. You may have desires, flashes of the past, and even terrible thoughts. They are attacks from demons. They are probing for a weakness. If they cannot get you to desire the things you are thinking of and act on the thoughts, they want you to "own" them and believe yourself to be a terrible, unrepentant person who is guaranteed to fall eventually. This leads to despondency, which is actually a kind of unbelief. And then we give up on prayer, and fasting, and reading, and we get in big trouble. Do not believe this lie! Just resist the thoughts. Pray.

When I have oppressive thoughts, I pray the Jesus prayer: **"Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy"**. sometimes I shorten it to **"Jesus have mercy."** If you pray, they will go away in time. Satan is a coward, and he will flee from heartfelt prayer.

Concerning mood swings. In our world, and especially in prison, bad things can happen quickly. You must pray when your heart is not right. You can do this anytime and anywhere. It is kind of like the spiritual way to "count to ten". Simple prayer works best. I pray for the person who is bothering me: "Lord have mercy on N.". I also rebuke my thoughts and ask the Lord to deliver me from them.

Edited, from <http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/prison-ministry-letters-2015-04-09+excerpts-from-letters+purpose-of-life-confessing-the-same-stuff-life-is-simple.html>

Life is simple.

Life is simple. My days filled with things that seem complex and much activity and fatigue however at its essence, life is always simple. How could it not be, when our Lord tells us: "My yoke is easy, and my burden is light?" (Mat 11:30) We make life complex. Life is about fulfilling our purpose, and God has made us capable of doing that, when He made us in His image. We

do good and avoid evil. When we do evil, we repent. We fulfill the two great commandments (love of God, and love of neighbor), because they make us more like God, so we can know God. We have complications in your life because of our desires, but still, life is simple. A person has a toxic relationship, or is not doing well in school, or sick, or is imprisoned, and

their loved ones loved ones are far away. In any case, we should be chaste and pray, and grow towards holiness. I know this is hard, but in essence, that's it!

There is so much happiness when we follow the will of God! Read the Gospels, pray, use that prayer book I gave you, read the Psalter. You will find a kindred spirit in David if you read the Psalms carefully. Edited, from http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/prison-ministry-letters_2015-04-09+excerpts-from-letters+purpose-of-life-confessing-the-same-stuff-life-is-simple.html

Sexual Sin.

Fornication is a grave sin, and most people don't even think it's a sin. Fornication is sexual relations outside of marriage, regardless of the genders of those involved in the sexual act. It may be homosexual or heterosexual fornication, or perhaps something stranger, since in our day in almost any kind of sexuality is lauded as virtuous. The (Orthodox) Christian church has always taught and will always teach that it is only possible for a man and a woman to be married. Therefore, all homosexual acts are fornication and are sinful.

In our society, there are those that are absolutely convinced that it is possible for two of the same gender to be married and that this marriage is blessed by God. There are also those who do not believe that sexual relations outside of marriage are sin. For many people, they are a "given". We cannot convince these people with logical arguments. Our pastoral problem is more about helping people to have enlightenment concerning their sinfulness. This enlightenment is not only that what they do or think or feel is sinful, but also that there is a way to conquer their sin.

This applies to much more than just sexual sin. We do not help people just by saying something is a grave sin. There must be personal contact and there must be way of welcoming people who are struggling. With this personal contact, we get to know someone, and see the reasons they are struggling with sin. These reasons are not excuses, but they have a bearing on how difficult it is for a person to extricate themselves from sin.

I don't really find it to be all that complicated. When I encounter a homosexual or somebody who is a fornicator, I love them, I talk to them, I

confess them, I have coffee with them, they come to dinner at my house, but I cannot give them communion. If they are trying to struggle against their sin, I help them GENTLY. If they are not struggling against their sin, then I do not force myself upon them. I also never treat homosexuality as some sort of arch-sin that is more evil than *any* other sin in the world, whereas the other sins are not so bad.

The reason why homosexuality is such a pernicious sin is because there is a whole culture built around it, including the creation of a God who is not. There are people who struggle with same-sex attraction, but they do not buy into the homosexual subculture. Those people are the ones that have the best chance to escape their sin.

This approach, with some variations, should be used for anyone who is mired in sin, or perhaps, has committed a sin, but has not come to enlightenment about it. For example, abortion is very pernicious sin because, until there is salvific and cathartic repentance, a person may become hardened regarding the sin, and much like the homosexual subculture, develop an entire subculture regarding abortion, or to be guilt stricken and full of shame. Shame will never save the soul. Shame is an indicator to the soul that it is to change.

Answers to: Questions about APOSTLES PETER AND PAUL

ANSWER 1

The Feast of the Holy Apostles Peter and Paul is June 29th, according to the church calendar. According to the civil calendar, this day falls on July 12th (Joe's garage calendar - the calendar that would be hanging on the wall in Joe's garage). The "Apostles Fast" precedes this great day.

ANSWER 2

The Apostles fast is different than all of our other fasts because its ending is fixed, but its beginning is variable.

The Nativity fast and the fast for the Mother of God (Dormition Fast) all begin on a fixed date and end on a fixed date no matter what year it is. The fast for Great Lent has variable beginning and end because it is always beginning 50 days before Pascha, which varies each year.

The Apostles Fast has a variable beginning; it always begins on the Monday following the Sunday after Pentecost (the Sunday of All Saints). Of course, the date of Pentecost, which is 50 days after Pascha and therefore depends on the date of Pascha, varies each year. The Apostles Fast ends with the feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul, which always occurs on a fixed date, June 29, according to the church calendar.

Because of the variable beginning in the fixed ending, the number of days of the Apostles Fast for those who follow the old calendar reckoning can be within this range: 8 to 42 days. To determine how long the fast is for those who follow the New Calendar, we must subtract 13 from each number. Therefore, for those on the New Calendar the Apostles Fast can be anywhere from -5 to 29 days. Of course, it makes no sense whatsoever to fast a *negative* number of days, so in those years, the feast is celebrated

without a fast preceding it since it occurs before or on the Sunday of All Saints. There is a terrible problem that those who have adopted the New Calendar have not been able to solve. For instance, this year, all churches began the apostles fast on June 28, according to the civil calendar, and the next day the new calendar reckoning was the feast day. Their fast was one day.

There are some who think that this is a minor issue, and bringing it up is just being hypercritical. In the church, everything matters. The Calendar change caused a lot of these kinds of problems. When Patriarch Meletios of sorrowful memory succeeded in getting the Church of Greece to change to the New Calendar reckoning, he also wanted to change the way Pascha was calculated and celebrate it with the Pope and the rest of those in the West. He was unable to do this, and we thank God that he was unable, however, now there is the problem that the two calendars which the church uses are not in sync anymore if one of those calendars is the new calendar.

ANSWER 3

The prokeimenon for all of the apostles is: **Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth, and their words unto the ends of the world.**

The Lord taught his apostles the way of life, and from that seed, the church spread throughout the entire world. We therefore say quite appropriately that their sound, that is, the teaching of the apostles, has gone forth into all the earth and their words unto the ends of the world.

Below is how the Prokeimenon is intoned in the Divine liturgy:

Reader: The Prokeimenon in the Eighth Tone:

Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth, and their words unto the ends of the world.

Chanters: Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth, * and their words unto the ends of the world.

Reader: The heavens declare the glory of God, and the firmament proclaimeth the work of His hands.

Chanters: Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth, * and their words unto the ends of the world.

Reader: Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth:

Chanters: And their words unto the ends of the world.

It is good to learn a bit of liturgical knowledge. The prokeimenon is a set of short verses usually from the Psalter, which are usually said before the reading of the Gospel or Epistle, whether it is in Matins or Divine liturgy or another service. There is also a prokeimenon that is sung after the Entrance at Vespers. There are a few other times a prokeimenon is used.

There is a certain way that the prokeimenon is sung. If it is the Divine liturgy, the person reading the epistle or epistles will intone the prokeimenon or prokeimena (plural). If it is matins, the deacon or the priest will intone it, and if it is Vespers, the deacon or the priest intones it.

No matter who is singing the prokeimenon, it is announced, the tone is given, and it is chanted in a plain voice.

The choir repeats this verse by singing it.

The person intoning the prokeimenon then plain chants the “Stichos”, which is another short verse that is usually from the Psalter. There is usually only one short verse but some prokeimena are called a “Great prokeimenon” and will have more than one Stichos.

The choir sings the Prokeimenon again, after each Stichos.

In Vespers or in matins, there is always only one prokeimenon; it is possible in the liturgy that there are two. If this is the case, the reader then plain chants the second prokeimenon, “in the # tone ..., Where “#” is a number from 1 through 8. The choir then sings this prokeimenon.

If there’s only one prokeimenon, the person intoning the prokeimenon will plain chant the first half of the prokeimenon and the choir will finish it, singing.

ANSWER 4

What significant event occurred that convinced Peter to evangelize the Gentiles?

It’s all in the acts of the apostles. Peter had a vision in the middle of the day where God directed him to go to the Gentiles; this was a monumental shift in the direction of the church. Up until this time, even though the Lord talked about the Gentiles many times and there are dozens if not hundreds of references to the Gentiles coming into belief in the Old Testament, the apostles thought that their mission was only to the Jews. Peter’s vision changed the direction of the entire church, and is the reason why you and I are Orthodox Christians.

Acts 11:1-18 And the apostles and brethren that were in Judaea heard that the Gentiles had also received the word of God. (2) And when Peter was come up to Jerusalem, they that were of the circumcision contended with him, (3) Saying, Thou wentest in to men uncircumcised, and didst eat with them. (4) But Peter rehearsed the matter from the beginning, and expounded it by order unto them, saying, (5) I was in the city of Joppa praying: and in a trance I saw a vision, A certain vessel descend, as it had been a great sheet, let down from heaven by four corners; and it came even to me: (6) Upon the which when I had fastened mine eyes, I considered, and saw fourfooted beasts of the earth, and wild beasts, and creeping things, and fowls of the air. (7) And I heard a voice saying unto me, Arise, Peter; slay and eat. (8) But I said, Not so, Lord: for nothing

common or unclean hath at any time entered into my mouth. (9) But the voice answered me again from heaven, What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common. (10) And this was done three times: and all were drawn up again into heaven. (11) And, behold, immediately there were three men already come unto the house where I was, sent from Caesarea unto me. (12) And the Spirit bade me go with them, nothing doubting. Moreover these six brethren accompanied me, and we entered into the man's house: (13) And he shewed us how he had seen an angel in his house, which stood and said unto him, Send men to Joppa, and call for Simon, whose surname is Peter; (14) Who shall tell thee words, whereby thou and all thy house shall be saved. (15) And as I began to speak, the Holy Ghost fell on them, as on us at the beginning. (16) Then remembered I the word of the Lord, how that he said, John indeed baptized with water; but ye shall be baptized with the Holy Ghost. (17) Forasmuch then as God gave them the like gift as he did unto us, who believed on the Lord Jesus Christ; what was I, that I could withstand God? (18) When they heard these things, they held their peace, and glorified God, saying, Then hath God also to the Gentiles granted repentance unto life.

ANSWER 5

The blessed Apostle Peter was martyred in Rome. Peter was crucified upside down, because he protested to his executioners that he was not worthy to be upright as his Lord was. We know this from holy tradition.

Our Lord Jesus Christ predicted how Peter would die: “Verily, verily, I say unto thee, When thou wast young, thou girdedst thyself, and walkedst whither thou wouldest: but when thou shalt be old, thou shalt stretch forth thy hands, and another shall gird thee, and carry thee whither thou wouldest not. (19) This spake he, signifying by what death he should glorify God. And when he had spoken this, he saith unto him, Follow me.” John 21:18-19

ANSWER 6

The blessed Apostle Paul was also martyred in Rome. Paul was beheaded. As a Roman citizen, he would not have been crucified, because this death was only used for foreigners. Beheading was considered to be a more humane death.

ANSWER 7

St. Paul was a Pharisee (called Saul before his conversion to Christianity) and very zealous for the Jewish faith. He considered Christians to be a heretical sect of lawbreaking Jews that should be stamped out. He possessed great authority to go about the countryside, killing Christians. His conversion is given in Acts on the so-called road to Damascus. He was on his way to kill more Christians when the Lord appeared to him, blinding him and speaking to him. It is best to let the Scripture tell the story.

Acts 9:1 And Saul, yet breathing out threatenings and slaughter against the disciples of the Lord, went unto the high priest, (2) And desired of him letters to Damascus to the synagogues, that if he found any of this way, whether they were men or women, he might bring them bound unto Jerusalem. (3) And as he journeyed, he came near Damascus: and suddenly there shined round about him a light from heaven: (4) And he fell to the earth, and heard a voice saying unto him, Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou me? (5) And he said, Who art thou, Lord? And the Lord said, I am Jesus whom thou persecutest: it is hard for thee to kick against the pricks. (6) And he trembling and astonished said, Lord, what wilt thou have me to do? And the Lord said unto him, Arise, and go into the city, and it shall be told thee what thou must do. (7) And the men which journeyed with him stood speechless, hearing a voice, but seeing no man. (8) And Saul arose from the earth; and when his eyes were opened, he saw no man: but they led him by the hand, and brought him into Damascus. (9) And he was three days

without sight, and neither did eat nor drink. (10) And there was a certain disciple at Damascus, named Ananias; and to him said the Lord in a vision, Ananias. And he said, Behold, I am here, Lord. (11) And the Lord said unto him, Arise, and go into the street which is called Straight, and enquire in the house of Judas for one called Saul, of Tarsus: for, behold, he prayeth, (12) And hath seen in a vision a man named Ananias coming in, and putting his hand on him, that he might receive his sight. (13) Then Ananias answered, Lord, I have heard by many of this man, how much evil he hath done to thy saints at Jerusalem: (14) And here he hath authority from the chief priests to bind all that call on thy name. (15) But the Lord said unto him, Go thy way: for he is a chosen vessel unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel: (16) For I will shew him how great things he must suffer for my name's sake. (17) And Ananias went his way, and entered into the house; and putting his hands on him said, Brother Saul, the Lord, even Jesus, that appeared unto thee in the way as thou camest, hath sent me, that thou mightest receive thy sight, and be filled with the Holy Ghost. (18) And immediately there fell from his eyes as it had been scales: and he received sight forthwith, and arose, and was baptized. (19) And when he had received meat, he was strengthened. Then was Saul certain days with the disciples which were at Damascus. (20) And straightway he preached Christ in the synagogues, that he is the Son of God. (21) But all that heard him were amazed, and said; Is not this he that destroyed them which called on this name in Jerusalem, and came hither for that intent, that he might bring them bound unto the chief priests? (22) But Saul increased the more in strength, and confounded the Jews which dwelt at Damascus, proving that this is very Christ. (23) And after that many days were fulfilled, the Jews took counsel to kill him: (24) But their laying await was known of Saul. And they watched the gates day and night to kill him. (25) Then the disciples took him by night, and let him down by the wall in a basket. (26) And when Saul was come to Jerusalem, he assayed to join himself to the disciples: but they were all afraid of him, and believed not that he was a disciple. (27) But Barnabas took him, and brought him to the apostles, and declared unto them how he had seen the Lord in the way, and that he had spoken to him, and how he had preached boldly at Damascus in the name of Jesus. (28) And he was with them coming in and going out at Jerusalem. (29) And he spake boldly in the name of the Lord Jesus, and disputed against the Grecians: but they went about to slay him. (30) Which when the brethren knew, they brought him down to Caesarea, and sent him forth to Tarsus. (31) Then had the churches rest throughout all Judaea and Galilee and Samaria, and were edified; and walking in the fear of the Lord, and in the comfort of the Holy Ghost, were multiplied. (32) And it came to pass, as Peter passed throughout all quarters, he came down also to the saints which dwelt at Lydda. Acts 9:1-32

ANSWER 8

Sometime during our Lord's forty days on earth after the resurrection, he appeared to seven of the disciples, who were fishing. This was an event similar to when He called some of them to be his disciples, but with significant differences, made possible by the passage of His three years of careful ministry to them. The first time the Lord told the apostles to "let down their nets" is chronicled in Luke 5:1-13. More than three years later, the risen Lord gives the same instruction, as St. John records (John 1:25, comprising the 10th and 11th matins resurrection gospels).

In the first case, our Lord only tells them to let down their nets, but to the time-tested apostles he tells them to let them down on the right side, and they obediently do so, as before, and are rewarded with a staggering catch of fish, which St John carefully mentions as one hundred fifty-three. He marvels that there were so many, and yet the net was not broken. When the apostles were as yet uninitiated and unlearned in spiritual things,

the catch of fish broke their nets, and even when they had brought another ship to help with the catch of fish, their boats began to sink. After their education and proving, their nets hold this great catch of fish, and one boat is able to contain it without sinking. These fishers of fish were truly made worthy and able to be great fishers of men, and their net, that is the Gospel and the Christian way of life, would never break again but will hold all those who come to the church.

In the previous instance, Peter was filled with fear, even asking the Lord to depart from him, as the as-yet uninitiated apostle felt the full weight of his sins in the presence of the God-man. In this latter case, the exuberant Peter cannot wait to be beside his Lord, throws on his fishers cloak, and casts himself into the sea. He who formerly had fear because of his sins now has confidence because He knows the Lord.

The first great catch of fish was too much for one ship, so another ship was pressed into service, although it proved inadequate to contain the catch of fish. In this second ship is shown in a mystery of the church's organization, with its bishops who are equal brothers and rightly divide the word of truth. In the latter case, only one ship, with the seven Apostles, was able to fulfill the word of the Lord and land all the fish. Here we see in an even more powerful way the church and the infinite resources those within it have to fulfill the commandments and contain all the fish, that is, souls, who are caught in the nets of the gospel.

After the other disciples landed their boats, and Peter pulled the net full of great fishes to land in obedience to the Lord's command (for all that is done in the church is in obedience to Christ), the Lord invited them to "Come and dine".

All the apostles knew it was the Lord and were filled with unspeakable joy.

After the meal, Jesus asked Peter three times if he loved Him, and restored his faith fully. There is a deep mystery in this, which we will only understand if we live the Christian life, and experience forgiveness and knowledge, as did Peter.

ANSWER 9

The apostle Paul is shown in the icon of Pentecost even though he certainly was not present. Several years after Pentecost Paul was yet not an apostle; he was a Pharisee who was busy trying to exterminate Christians. His conversion occurred at least a decade after Pentecost.

The church puts Paul in the icon because she is trying to teach a spiritual reality and not just in a historical event. Once Paul was converted, he was as much a child of Pentecost as all of the apostles, and he and Peter came to be known as the most influential apostles.

ANSWER 10

After a great feast, its customary on the next day to remember others that are associated in some way with the feast. We call this commemoration a "Synaxis", which means gathering. We gather together all of those involved in the feast which were not given prominence. For instance, the day after Nativity, we have the "Synaxis of the Theotokos, " the day after the baptism of the Lord, we have the "Synaxis of John the Baptist." The day after the commemoration of the Apostles Peter and Paul, we have the "Synaxis of the 12 Holy Apostles."

http://www.orthodox.net/questions/peter_and_paul_1.html
http://www.orthodox.net/questions/peter_and_paul_1.doc

¹ The Feast of the Holy Apostles Peter and Paul is on June 29th according to the church calendar, which is July 12 on the “wall calendar”. It follows a fasting period that begins on the Monday after the Sunday of All Saints. This is the second Monday after Pentecost, and this is the only major fast that has a variable beginning day, and a fixed ending day. Great Lent, which precedes Pascha, has a variable beginning and ending date each year. The other two major fasting periods – the two weeks before the Dormition (Aug 1-14, church calendar), and the fast before the Nativity of Christ, begin and end on fixed calendar dates every year.

² John 21:15-25

³ The eleven Resurrectional Gospels all refer to the events in the resurrection and are read in an 11 week repeated cycles. There is one from Matthew, two from Mark, three from Luke and five from John. These Gospels are read at Sunday matins.

⁴ Psalm 18:5 (Sept), also quoted in Romans 10:18. This is part of the prokeimenon for the Apostles, which we use on their feast and on every Thursday at liturgy, before we read the Epistle. The church knows this psalm to be a prophecy regarding the evangelism of the Apostles and their successors.

⁵ The word for love used by Christ the first two times is “agape” which denotes the highest, purest love. It is the love of God for us and the love we should have for God. It is the perfect fulfillment of the Greatest commandment, and certainly by extension, since the “second one is like it”, the way we must love everyone. “Then one of them, *which was a lawyer*, asked *him a question*, tempting him, and saying, (36) Master, which *is* the great commandment in the law? (37) Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. (38) This is the first and great commandment. (39) And the second *is* like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbor as thyself. (40) On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.” (Mat 22:35-40 KJV)

⁶ Agape – the highest love.

phileo – to be a friend of, to have affection for (Philadelphia Pennsylvania is known as the city of brotherly love)

Eros – often refers to erotic love.

⁷ John 13:37-38 “Peter said unto him, Lord, why cannot I follow thee now? I will lay down my life for thy sake. (38) Jesus answered him, Wilt thou lay down thy life for my sake? Verily, verily, I say unto thee, The cock shall not crow, till thou hast denied me thrice.”

John 18:25-27 KJV “And Simon Peter stood and warmed himself. They said therefore unto him, Art not thou also *one* of his disciples? He denied *it*, and said, I am not. (26) One of the servants of the high priest, being *his* kinsman whose ear Peter cut off, saith, Did not I see thee in the garden with him? (27) Peter then denied again: and immediately the cock crew.”

⁸ Phileo – affectionate love. This is no doubt a powerful love, but it is not as perfect as agape.

⁹ “Of the Jews five times received I forty stripes save one. 25 Thrice was I beaten with rods, once was I stoned, thrice I suffered shipwreck, a night and a day I have been in the deep; 26 In journeyings often, in perils of waters, in perils of robbers, in perils by mine own countrymen, in perils by the heathen, in perils in the city, in perils in the wilderness, in perils in the sea, in perils among false brethren; 27 In weariness and painfulness, in watchings often, in hunger and thirst, in fastings often, in cold and nakedness. 28 Beside those things that are without, that which cometh upon me daily, the care of all the churches.” (2 Corinthians 11:24-28) from the selection read at liturgy for the Apostles Peter and Paul (2 Corinthians 11:21-12:9)

¹⁰ “And we have known and believed the love that God hath to us. God is love; and he that dwelleth in love dwelleth in God, and God in him.” (1John 4:16 KJV) OF COURSE, the word for love used is “agape”.

¹¹ The parable of the Good Samaritan. This is read on the 25th Sunday after Pentecost.

“And, behold, a certain lawyer stood up, and tempted him, saying, Master, what shall I do to inherit eternal life? (26) He said unto him, What is written in the law? how readest thou? (27) And he answering said, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy strength, and with all thy mind; and thy neighbor as thyself. (28) And he said unto him, Thou hast answered right: this do, and thou shalt live. (29) But he, willing to justify himself, said unto Jesus, And who is my neighbor? (30) And Jesus answering said, A certain *man* went down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among thieves, which stripped him of his raiment, and wounded *him*, and departed, leaving *him* half dead. (31) And by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. (32) And likewise a Levite, when he was at the place, came and looked *on him*, and passed by on the other side. (33) But a certain Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was: and when he saw him, he had compassion *on him*, (34) And went to *him*, and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him. (35) And on the morrow when he departed, he took out two pence, and gave *them* to the host, and said unto him, Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I come again, I will repay thee. (36) Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was neighbor unto him that fell among the thieves? (37) And he said, He that shewed mercy on him. Then said Jesus unto him, Go, and do thou likewise. (Luke 10:25-37)

¹² 1 Peter 1:3

¹³ There is a repeating cycle of 11 Resurrection Gospels, each read in its turn at Sunday Matins. The first is from Mark, the second two are from Mark, the next three are from Luke, and the last five from John. They all detail events from the end of the Gospels, from the day of the Resurrection onwards. These are among the most important AND LEAST LISTENED TO Gospels in the church year, since most Christians do not consider Matins to be an important service, judging from their attendance. This is a great tragedy for them. We cannot hear or meditate enough about the resurrection, and in the Matins service, there is a great grace that increased the understanding when we hear these scriptures.

¹⁴ This stuff is really important, and therefore has been mentioned in other homilies. This one - http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/feasts-of-the-saints-06-29_2008-07-12+holy-apostles-peter-and-paul.html has a more lengthy discourse about the kinds of love “agape” and “phileo” and why the way Christ asked and Peter answered is significant. Also in Word form: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/feasts-of-the-saints-06-29_2008-07-12+holy-apostles-peter-and-paul.doc and Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/feasts-of-the-saints-06-29_2008-07-12+holy-apostles-peter-and-paul.mp3

¹⁵ The word for love used by Christ the first two times is “agape” which denotes the highest, purest love. It is the love of God for us and the love we should have for God. It is the perfect fulfillment of the Greatest commandment, and certainly by extension, since the “second one is like it”, the way we must love everyone. “Then one of them, *which was a lawyer*, asked *him a question*, tempting him, and saying, (36) Master, which *is* the great commandment in the law? (37) Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. (38) This is the first and great commandment. (39) And the second *is* like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbor as thyself. (40) On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.” (Mat 22:35-40 KJV) – footnote taken from http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/feasts-of-the-saints-06-29_2008-07-12+holy-apostles-peter-and-paul.doc

¹⁶ Agape – the highest love.

phileo – to be a friend of, to have affection for (Philadelphia Pennsylvania is known as the city of brotherly love)

Eros – often refers to erotic love. Ibid.

¹⁷ 1 Peter 1:13

¹⁸ Mat 11:12 KJV “And from the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force.”

¹⁹ 1Peter 1:14-15 KJV

²⁰ This homily was given at the Vigil for the Apostles Peter and Paul, between Vespers and Matins. Because of work schedules, the service did not begin until about 7:45 pm.

²¹ The last blessing of Vespers, when served at a vigil after which the Six Psalms immediately begin.